# Trace-characterising inequalities fail with the Michelson contrast of the functional and of the operators, and projections detect the failure

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**Abstract**

Many inequalities that hold for the trace characterise it: a positive functional that satisfies one of them for all operators is a trace. We study 25 such characterisations from the literature, among them Gardner's inequality $|\varphi(X)| \le \varphi(|X|)$, the triangle inequality for $\varphi(|\cdot|)$, monotonicity, Young's, Araki–Lieb–Thirring's, Peierls–Bogoliubov's and determinant inequalities, and inequalities for pairs of projections, and ask how strongly they fail for a non-tracial functional $\varphi = \mathrm{Tr}(W\,\cdot)$ on $M_n$. Our main observation is common to all of them: the violation is governed by Michelson contrasts. It vanishes when the density $W$ or the operators entering the inequality have contrast zero, and it rises with both. For Gardner's inequality and its relatives we prove that the sharp constant depends on the two contrasts only through their product, $|\varphi(X)| \le (1-\Delta(W)^2\Delta(|X|)^2)^{-1/2}\varphi(|X|)$ in even dimension, with an explicit value in odd dimension. With the operators free, we determine the envelope as a function of $\delta = \Delta(W)$ exactly in sixteen cases and give lower bounds in four; the envelopes vanish at the trace to the orders $\delta$, $\delta^2$, $\delta^4$ and $\delta^8$, and the sharp constants are the Kantorovich constant, the condition number and the Specht ratio of $W$. On a direct sum $\bigoplus_c M_{k_c}$ only the contrast inside the blocks counts. A certified numerical search over all operators shows how the largest violation is attained: at projections for most characterisations, at two-level operators $\ell+(1-\ell)P$ for the others, so that in practice it suffices to test an inequality on projections and their affine images. Random sampling confirms both theses from the other side: random operators rarely violate the inequalities, and for monotonicity, subadditivity and the Powers–Størmer inequality essentially never, while samples of scaled projections violate them many times more often. The search also exhibits the exceptions: a threshold in the contrast of the operators below which no violation occurs (monotonicity, subadditivity, the spectral geometric mean), a peak at the contrast of the density (the determinant inequality), invariance under shifts (Peierls–Bogoliubov), and two inequalities that in dimension three are violated more strongly by operators that are not two-level. Finally, we determine the sharp bound of the unnormalised violation $|\mathrm{Tr}(XZ)| - \mathrm{Tr}(X|Z|)$ with both contrasts prescribed, which answers a question raised in earlier work by Abed and the authors.

**Keywords:** trace characterisation; positive functional; Michelson contrast; Kantorovich inequality; Specht ratio; two projections; two-level operators; von Neumann algebra.
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## 1 Introduction

Let $\varphi$ be a positive linear functional on a C*-algebra. Gardner [18] proved that $\varphi$ is a trace, $\varphi(XY) = \varphi(YX)$, if and only if

$$|\varphi(X)| \le \varphi(|X|) \qquad \text{for all } X. \tag{1}$$

This started a long series of results of the same form: an inequality that holds for every trace holds for all operators only if $\varphi$ is a trace. On $M_n$ or among the positive normal functionals on a von Neumann

algebra, traces are characterised by the triangle inequality for $\varphi(|\cdot|)$ [18, 30], by $|\varphi(A^k)| \le \varphi(|A|^k)$ [27], by monotonicity $0 \le A \le B \Rightarrow \varphi(A^p) \le \varphi(B^p)$ [5, 28] and its weighted forms [21, 22], by Young's inequality [4, 16], by subadditivity of $\varphi \circ f$ for concave $f$ [31], by the Peierls–Bogoliubov and Araki–Lieb–Thirring inequalities [9], by the generalised Powers–Størmer inequality [23], by inequalities for determinants and power means [12], by the spectral geometric mean [15], by inequalities for $|\varphi(A^2)|$ [14], by metrics on projections [11], by subadditivity on the projection lattice [27, Theorem 4], and by a family of inequalities in which only projections enter [6, 7, 8, 10]. Bikchentaev and Moslehian [13] survey these results; the canonical trace on $M_n$ is characterised in [25, 12]. The dual problem, in which the functional is arbitrary and the operator is to be characterised as central, is treated in [26].

All these theorems answer a yes/no question. Here we ask a quantitative one: *how strongly does a trace-characterising inequality fail for a given non-tracial functional?* On $M_n$ every positive functional has the form $\varphi_W = \mathrm{Tr}(W\,\cdot\,)$ with a density $W \ge 0$, and $\varphi_W$ is a trace if and only if $W$ is a scalar multiple of 1. The natural measure of the distance of $W$ from the scalars that is invariant under scaling is the Michelson contrast

$$\Delta(W) = \frac{\lambda_{\max}(W) - \lambda_{\min}(W)}{\lambda_{\max}(W) + \lambda_{\min}(W)} \in [0, 1],$$

studied for operators in [1]. There, a Monte Carlo study [1, Sect. 5.1, Fig. 1] plotted the violation of Gardner's inequality against $\Delta(W)$ for real $2 \times 2$ and $3 \times 3$ matrices and conjectured that such violations are bounded by functions of the contrasts [1, Sect. 7]. We make this precise. For an inequality $L \le R$ (with $L$, $R$ depending on $\varphi$ and on operator variables) the *violation envelope* is

$$V_n(\delta) = \sup\Big\{ \frac{L - R}{N} : \; W \ge 0 \text{ in } M_n, \; \Delta(W) = \delta, \text{ all operator variables free} \Big\},$$

where $N > 0$ is a normalisation that makes the quotient invariant under the scaling of $W$ and of the variables (mostly $N = R$). By the characterisation theorems, $V_n(\delta) > 0$ for $\delta > 0$; by construction $V_n(0) = 0$.

**Two theses.** We study the 25 inequalities of Table 1 and find two properties that hold for all of them, with exceptions that we identify.

*(I) The violation is governed by contrasts.* Besides the contrast $\delta$ of the density we prescribe the contrast $\delta'$ of the operators that enter the inequality (of their moduli, for operators that are not positive). If either is zero there is no violation (Proposition 2.4); the violation needs a functional far from a trace *and* operators far from scalars. For Gardner's inequality the envelope is a function of the product alone:

$$V_n(\delta, \delta') = \frac{1}{\sqrt{1 - \delta^2 \delta'^2}} - 1 \qquad (n \text{ even}),$$

with an explicit, slightly smaller value for odd $n$ (Theorem 4.1), and the same bound holds for the triangle inequality and for $\varphi(A + A^*) \le 2\varphi(|A^*|)$. For the extended Young inequality the operators $A = B$ with two-level modulus give $4\delta\delta'/(1 + \delta'^2 - 2\delta\delta')$, linear in each contrast (Proposition 5.3). For the remaining items Figure 3 shows $V(\delta, \delta')$ from a certified search: it rises with $\delta'$ for most of them, but some (monotonicity, subadditivity, the spectral geometric mean, the Powers–Størmer and the power-mean inequality) are violated only by operators of contrast close to 1, the determinant inequality is violated most strongly when the contrast of $A$ equals that of $W$, and the Peierls–Bogoliubov inequality, being invariant under $A \mapsto A + c$, $B \mapsto B + c$, does not see the contrast of the operators at all.

*(II) Projections detect the failure.* A positive operator of contrast $\delta'$ with only two eigenvalues is, up to a factor, $\ell' + (1 - \ell')P$ with a projection $P$. We call it *two-level*. Whenever the violation depends

convexly on the spectrum of a variable, its maximum is attained at two-level operators (Lemma 2.5); this is the mechanism behind all closed forms below. Numerically (Table 3), in $M_2$ the largest violation over all operators is attained, or approached, by (scaled) projections for 22 of the 25 items (for 11 of them the variables are projections by definition) and by two-level operators for the other three; in $M_3$ the same holds except for the spectral geometric mean and the generalised Powers–Størmer inequality, which at large contrast are violated more strongly by operators that are not two-level. In practice, an inequality characterising the trace can be tested on projections and their affine images. Random sampling (Section 9.2) shows why this matters: random operators violate subadditivity, monotonicity and the Powers–Størmer inequality in fewer than one sample in a thousand, scaled projections in 0.7 to 21% of the samples, and for Gardner's inequality the fraction rises from 4% to 19%.

**Results with the operators free.** Write $a \geq b > 0$ for the extreme eigenvalues of $W$ and

$$h = \frac{a}{b} = \frac{1+\delta}{1-\delta}, \qquad \kappa = \frac{a+b}{2\sqrt{ab}} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{1-\delta^2}}, \qquad \psi = \arcsin\delta,$$

the condition number, the Kantorovich constant and the contrast angle of $W$.

**Theorem A.** *The envelopes of the inequalities of Table 1 are as follows.*

*(a)* $V_n = \kappa - 1$ *for Gardner's inequality, the triangle inequalities for* $\varphi(|\cdot|)$ *on operators and on projections,* $\varphi(A+A^*) \leq 2\varphi(|A^*|)$, $|\varphi(A^2)| \leq \varphi(A^*A)$, $\varphi(|P-Q|) \leq \varphi(P+Q)$ *and* $\varphi(\operatorname{Re} PQ) \leq \varphi(|PQ|)$, *in every dimension* $n \geq 2$ *(Theorem 3.1, Theorem 6.1).*

*(b)* $V_n = \kappa^2 - 1$ *for* $\varphi(PQP) \leq \varphi(Q)$; $V_n = \frac{1}{2}\tan^2(\psi/2)$ *for* $\varphi(\operatorname{Re} PQ) \geq 0$; $V_n = \delta/(1-\delta)$ *for* $\varphi(P \vee Q) \leq \varphi(P) + \varphi(Q)$; $V_n = \delta$ *for* $\varphi(P+Q) \leq \varphi(1 + P \wedge Q)$ *(n even); and* $V_n$ *is the maximum of an explicit function of one variable,* $\frac{(e-1)^2}{e(e+1)}\delta^2 + O(\delta^3)$, *for* $\varphi(e^{QPQ}) \leq \varphi(e^P)$ *(n even) (Theorem 6.1).*

*(c)* $V_n = h - 1$ *for the extension of Young's inequality to arbitrary operators;* $V_2 = s/(1+s)$, $s = \sin(\psi/2)$, *for* $\varphi(PQ+QP) \leq 2\varphi(QPQ)$; *for the inequalities that characterise the* canonical *trace,* $V_2 = 1 - \sqrt{1-\delta^2}$ *for the AM–GM inequality* $(\det A)^{1/n} \leq \frac{1}{n}\varphi(A)$, *increasing with n to* $1 - 1/S(h)$ *with the Specht ratio S, and* $V_n = \sqrt{(\ell+n-1)/(n\ell)} - 1$, $\ell = 1/h$, *for* $\varphi(A^2)^{1/2} \leq \varphi(A)$ *(Section 5).*

*(d)* $V_n \geq \kappa - 1$ *for the spectral geometric mean inequality,* $V_n \geq \kappa^2 - 1$ *for the Araki–Lieb–Thirring inequality,* $V_n \geq \delta^4/16 + O(\delta^5)$ *for monotonicity and* $V_n \geq \delta^8/4096\,(1 + O(\delta^2))$ *for its weighted form with* $r = 1$; *and* $V_n \leq h - 1$ *for the first ten items (Section 7).*

Thus the envelopes vanish at the trace to different orders, $\delta$, $\delta^2$, $\delta^4$ and $\delta^8$ (Table 4): some characterisations are far more sensitive than others, and two inequalities that are equivalent for traces may fail at different rates. For instance, $\varphi(P \vee Q) + \varphi(P \wedge Q) = \varphi(P) + \varphi(Q)$ for every trace, yet the lattice subadditivity fails as $\delta/(1-\delta)$ and $\varphi(|P-Q|) \leq \varphi(P+Q)$, with the same right-hand side, only as $\kappa - 1 \sim \delta^2/2$.

The second result concerns finite-dimensional von Neumann algebras $\mathcal{M} = \bigoplus_{c=1}^{C} M_{k_c}$. A positive functional $\varphi_W$ on $\mathcal{M}$ is a trace if and only if $W$ is central, i.e. scalar on every block, however different the scalars are. The violation therefore cannot depend on the global contrast of $W$:

**Theorem B.** *Let* $W = \bigoplus_c W_c > 0$ *in* $\mathcal{M}$. *For every inequality of Table 1 except 11, 16 and 24, the largest normalised violation for* $\varphi_W$ *on* $\mathcal{M}$ *is at most the largest one for* $\varphi_{W_c}$ *on the blocks* $M_{k_c}$, *with equality for items 1–10, 12–14, 17, 18, 21–23 and 25. In particular a density that varies only between the blocks produces no violation at all (Theorem 8.1).*

The third result returns to the unnormalised quantity of [1], in which both operators are normalised to norm one and both contrasts are prescribed:

**Theorem C.** *Let* $\mathcal{M} = \bigoplus_{c=1}^{C} M_{k_c}(\mathbb{K})$, $\mathbb{K} \in \{\mathbb{R}, \mathbb{C}\}$, $N = \sum_c \lfloor k_c/2 \rfloor \geq 1$. *For* $X \geq 0$ *and* $Z$ *in* $\mathcal{M}$ *with* $\|X\| = \|Z\| = 1$, $\Delta(X) = \delta < 1$ *and* $\Delta(|Z|) = \delta'$,

$$\sup\bigl(|\operatorname{Tr}(XZ)| - \operatorname{Tr}(X|Z|)\bigr) = \frac{N\,\delta^2\delta'^2}{(1+\delta)(1+\delta')},$$

*and the supremum is attained (Theorem 4.3).*

All values in Theorems A and C and in Theorem 4.1 are confirmed by a certified numerical search over all variables, which also gives the envelopes of the five inequalities without a closed form (Section 9).

**What is new.** The characterisation theorems are due to the cited authors, and the constants $\kappa$, $h$ and the Specht ratio, as well as the inequalities behind them (Kantorovich's inequality in the form of Greub and Rheinboldt [19, 17], Specht's reverse AM–GM inequality [29]), are classical. The upper bounds of Theorem 3.1 are the Kantorovich inequality; what we add is that the resulting constants are the exact envelopes. We found no previous study of the envelopes; the closest work is [1], which plots the unnormalised Gardner violation, defines no envelope and proves no bound. A short account of part of these results appears as a use case in the description of the software used for the computations [24].

**Organisation.** Section 2 fixes the notation, lists the inequalities, introduces the contrast of the operators and collects the tools, among them the vertex principle. Section 4 treats Gardner's inequality with both contrasts (Theorem 4.1 and Theorem C); Sections 3, 5, 6 and 7 prove Theorem A, and Section 8 Theorem B. Section 9 reports the numerical results on both theses, and Section 10 concludes.

## 2 Setting and tools

### 2.1 Functionals, contrast and envelopes

Throughout, Tr is the usual trace on $M_n = M_n(\mathbb{C})$, $|X| = (X^*X)^{1/2}$, $\|X\|_1 = \operatorname{Tr}|X|$, $\operatorname{Re} X = \frac{1}{2}(X + X^*)$, and $\varphi = \varphi_W = \operatorname{Tr}(W\,\cdot\,)$ with $W \geq 0$; $\varphi$ is a trace iff $W \in \mathbb{C}1$. We write $a \geq b$ for the extreme eigenvalues of $W$, $e_1, e_2$ for corresponding unit eigenvectors, and $\delta = \Delta(W)$; unless stated otherwise $W > 0$, i.e. $\delta < 1$. The quotient $(L - R)/N$ is invariant under $W \mapsto tW$, $t > 0$, and the envelope $V_n(\delta)$ is the supremum over all $W$ with $\Delta(W) = \delta$; for a fixed density we write $V(W)$. We call a value of an envelope *attained* if the supremum is a maximum and *approached* otherwise. Variables called $P, Q, R$ are orthogonal projections, $A, B \geq 0$ unless said otherwise, and $X, Y$ arbitrary; $P \wedge Q$ and $P \vee Q$ are the projections onto $\operatorname{ran} P \cap \operatorname{ran} Q$ and onto $\operatorname{ran} P + \operatorname{ran} Q$.

### 2.2 Remarks on the forms

Several sources state families of inequalities; we use one member. In item 4, $|\varphi(A^k)| \leq \varphi(|A|^k)$ for all $A$ and one fixed $k \geq 1$ characterises the trace on $M_n$ [27, Theorem 1]; $k = 1$ is Gardner's inequality. Item 7 is the Araki–Lieb–Thirring inequality $\varphi((B^{1/2}AB^{1/2})^{rp}) \leq \varphi((B^{r/2}A^rB^{r/2})^p)$ with $r = 2$, $p = 1$ [9, Lemma 2]. The published form of item 8 is $\varphi(|AB|) \leq \frac{1}{p}\varphi(A^p) + \frac{1}{q}\varphi(B^q)$ for $A, B \geq 0$ [4]; we use $p = q = 2$ and allow arbitrary $A, B$, in the form of Ando's matrix Young inequality [2], and Proposition 5.1 refers to this extension. Item 9 is the member $p = 1$ of the family $\varphi(PQ + QP) \leq$

| | inequality $L \le R$ | variables | $N$ | source |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | $\lvert\varphi(X)\rvert \le \varphi(\lvert X\rvert)$ | $X$ | $R$ | [18] |
| 2 | $\varphi(\lvert X+Y\rvert) \le \varphi(\lvert X\rvert)+\varphi(\lvert Y\rvert)$ | $X, Y$ | $R$ | [18, 30] |
| 3 | $\varphi(A+A^*) \le 2\varphi(\lvert A^*\rvert)$ | $A$ arbitrary | $R$ | [10] |
| 4 | $\lvert\varphi(A^2)\rvert \le \varphi(A^*A)$ | $A$ arbitrary | $R$ | [27, Thm. 1, $k=2$], [14] |
| 5 | $\varphi(\lvert P-R\rvert) \le \varphi(\lvert P-Q\rvert)+\varphi(\lvert Q-R\rvert)$ | $P, Q, R$ | $R$ | [11] |
| 6 | $\varphi(A \natural B) \le \sqrt{\varphi(A)\varphi(B)}$ | $A, B > 0$ | $R$ | [15] |
| 7 | $\varphi((B^{1/2}AB^{1/2})^2) \le \varphi(BA^2B)$ | $A, B$ | $R$ | [9, Lemma 2, $r=2$, $p=1$] |
| 8 | $\varphi(\lvert AB^*\rvert) \le \frac{1}{2}\varphi(\lvert A\rvert^2)+\frac{1}{2}\varphi(\lvert B\rvert^2)$ | $A, B$ arbitrary | $R$ | extension of [4] |
| 9 | $\varphi(PQ+QP) \le 2\varphi(QPQ)$ | $P, Q$ | $\varphi(P)+\varphi(Q)$ | [10] |
| 10 | $0 \le A \le B \Rightarrow \varphi(A^2) \le \varphi(B^2)$ | $A \le B$ | $R$ | [5, 28] |
| 11 | $(\det A)^{1/n} \le \frac{1}{n}\varphi(A)$, $\varphi(1)=n$ | $A$ | $(\det A)^{1/n}$ | [12, Thm. 3(iii)] |
| 12 | $\varphi((A+B)^{1/2}) \le \varphi(A^{1/2})+\varphi(B^{1/2})$ | $A, B$ | $R$ | [31, Cor. 1] |
| 13 | $\varphi(A+B-\lvert A-B\rvert) \le 2\varphi(A^{1/4}B^{1/2}A^{1/4})$ | $A, B$ | $\varphi(A+B)$ | [23, Lemma 3.1] |
| 14 | $\lvert\varphi(PQ)\rvert \le \varphi(P)^{1/3}\varphi(Q)^{2/3}$ | $P, Q$ | $R$ | [8, Thm. 2(i)] |
| 15 | $\varphi(e^{P+Q}) \le \varphi(e^{P/2}e^Qe^{P/2})$ | $P, Q$ | $R$ | [8, Thm. 2(iv)] |
| 16 | $\varphi(e^A)\exp\frac{\varphi(e^{A/2}Be^{A/2})}{\varphi(e^A)} \le \varphi(e^{A+B})$ | $A, B$ self-adj. | $R$ | [9, Lemma 1] |
| 17 | $\varphi(PQP) \le \varphi(Q)$ | $P, Q$ | $R$ | [7, Thm. 3.4(iv)] |
| 18 | $\varphi(\lvert P-Q\rvert) \le \varphi(P+Q)$ | $P, Q$ | $R$ | [7, Thm. 3.4(v)] |
| 19 | $\varphi(P+Q) \le \varphi(1+P\wedge Q)$ | $P, Q$ | $R$ | [7, Thm. 3.4(iii)] |
| 20 | $\varphi(e^{QPQ}) \le \varphi(e^P)$ | $P, Q$ | $R$ | [8, Thm. 2(v)] |
| 21 | $0 \le \varphi(\operatorname{Re} PQ)$ | $P, Q$ | $\varphi(P)+\varphi(Q)$ | [8, Thm. 2(vi)] |
| 22 | $\varphi(\operatorname{Re} PQ) \le \varphi(\lvert PQ\rvert)$ | $P, Q$ | $R$ | [8, Thm. 2(vii)] |
| 23 | $\varphi(P\vee Q) \le \varphi(P)+\varphi(Q)$ | $P, Q$ | $R$ | [27, Thm. 4] |
| 24 | $\varphi(A^2)^{1/2} \le \varphi(A)$, $\varphi(1)=n$ | $A$ | $R$ | [12, Thm. 3(vii)] |
| 25 | $0 \le A \le B \Rightarrow \varphi(A^4) \le \varphi(AB^2A)$ | $A \le B$ | $R$ | [22, Thms. 4, 5, $r=1$], [21] |

Table 1: The inequalities studied, with the normalisation $N$ of the violation $(L-R)/N$ and the source of the characterisation. Projections are $P, Q, R$; positive operators $A, B$ unless stated otherwise. Remarks on the forms are in Section 2.2.

$2\varphi((QPQ)^p)$, $p \in (0,1]$ [10]. Items 10 and 25 are the cases $r=0$ and $r=1$ of $\varphi(A^{2r+2}) \le \varphi(A^rB^2A^r)$ for $0 \le A \le B$, which characterises traces for every fixed $r \ge 0$ [22, Lemma 1, Theorems 4, 5]; on $M_n$ the case $r=0$ is in [5, 28] and $r>0$ in [21, Theorem 6]. Items 11 and 24 characterise the canonical trace among the positive functionals with $\varphi(1)=n$ [12, Theorem 3]; item 24 is (vii) there with $p=2$, $q=1$ and needs $\varphi$ faithful. Item 12 is the case $f(t)=t^{1/2}$ of Tikhonov's characterisation by $\varphi(f(A+B)) \le \varphi(f(A))+\varphi(f(B))$ for concave $f$ with $f(0)=0$ [31, Corollary 1]. Item 13 is the generalised Powers–Størmer inequality $\varphi(A+B)-\varphi(\lvert A-B\rvert) \le 2\varphi(f(A)^{1/2}g(B)f(A)^{1/2})$, $g(t)=t/f(t)$, with $f(t)=t^{1/2}$ [23, Lemma 3.1, Remark 4]; with $N=R$ its envelope would be infinite (Remark 7.3), so we normalise by $\varphi(A+B)$. Item 14 is Hölder's inequality for projections with the exponent $\alpha=3$; for $\alpha=2$ it holds for every positive $\varphi$ [8, remark after Theorem 2]. Item 16 is the Peierls–Bogoliubov inequality, stated in [9] for positive $H, K$; both sides scale by $e^c$ under $A \mapsto A+c$, $B \mapsto B+c$, so the envelope over self-adjoint arguments is the same. Items 17–19 are [7, Theorem 3.4], announced in [6], and items 14, 15, 20–22 are [8, Theorem 2].

### 2.3 Tools

**Lemma 2.1** (Kantorovich inequality [19]). *If $b \le W \le a$, $a \ge b > 0$, then $\omega(W^2)\,\omega(1) \le \kappa^2\,\omega(W)^2$ for every positive functional $\omega$, where $\kappa = (a+b)/(2\sqrt{ab})$.*

*Proof.* $(a-W)(W-b) \ge 0$ gives $\omega(W^2) \le (a+b)x - ab\,y$ with $x=\omega(W)$, $y=\omega(1)$, and $((a+b)x-$

$aby)y \le \kappa^2 x^2$ because the difference is $(\kappa x - \sqrt{ab}\,y)^2$. □

**Lemma 2.2** (Two projections; Halmos [20]). *For projections $P, Q$ on a finite-dimensional Hilbert space $H$, $H$ is the orthogonal sum of subspaces of dimension 1 or 2 invariant under $P$ and $Q$. On each two-dimensional one there is an orthonormal basis $f, f'$ with $P = ff^*$ and $Q = qq^*$, $q = \cos\theta\, f + e^{i\chi}\sin\theta\, f'$, $0 < \theta < \pi/2$.*

The next lemma gives a general upper bound; it shows that no envelope of items 1–8 and 10 can exceed the order $\delta$.

**Lemma 2.3.** *For items 1–8 and 10, $V(W) \le h - 1$.*

*Proof.* In each item $L \le aL_0$, where $L_0$ is the expression for the trace or the trace norm (e.g. $|\varphi(X)| \le a\|X\|_1$, $\varphi(|X+Y|) \le a\,\mathrm{Tr}\,|X+Y|$, $|\varphi(A^2)| \le a\|A^2\|_1$), $L_0 \le R_{\mathrm{Tr}}$ by the trace inequality (for item 4 $\|A^2\|_1 \le \|A\|_2^2$; for item 7 the Araki–Lieb–Thirring inequality; for item 6, $A\natural B$ is unitarily similar to $(A^{1/2}BA^{1/2})^{1/2}$, so $\mathrm{Tr}(A\natural B) = \|A^{1/2}B^{1/2}\|_1 \le (\mathrm{Tr}\,A\,\mathrm{Tr}\,B)^{1/2}$), and $R \ge bR_{\mathrm{Tr}}$. Hence $L/R \le a/b = h$. For item 8, $\varphi(|AB^*|) \le a\|A\|_2\|B\|_2 \le \frac{a}{2}(\|A\|_2^2 + \|B\|_2^2)$. □

## 2.4 Contrasts of the operator variables

The envelope $V_n(\delta)$ lets the operator variables range over all operators. To see how the violation depends on the operators themselves, we also prescribe their contrast. For a positive variable $A$ we use $\Delta(A)$, for an arbitrary or self-adjoint variable $X$ the contrast $\Delta(|X|)$ of its modulus (for the Peierls–Bogoliubov inequality, item 16, the variables are positive, as in [9]), and we let every operator variable of an item have the same contrast $\delta' \in [0,1]$:

$$V_n(\delta,\delta') = \sup\Big\{\frac{L-R}{N} :\ \Delta(W) = \delta,\ \text{every operator variable of contrast } \delta'\Big\}.$$

Projections other than 0 and 1 have contrast 1, so for items 5, 9, 14, 15 and 17–23 only $\delta' = 1$ occurs, and $V_n(\delta,1) \le V_n(\delta)$ with equality whenever the supremum over all operators is approached by singular ones. A positive operator of contrast $\delta'$ whose spectrum has only two points is, up to a positive factor,

$$A = \ell' + (1-\ell')P, \qquad \ell' = \frac{1-\delta'}{1+\delta'}, \qquad P \text{ a projection},\ P \ne 0,1;$$

we call such operators *two-level*. They are the affine images of projections, and as $\delta' \to 1$ they become scaled projections.

**Proposition 2.4.** *If every operator variable is a positive multiple of the identity (for arbitrary and self-adjoint variables: if every modulus is), then $L \le R$ in every item of Table 1 and for every positive $\varphi$. Hence $V_n(\delta,0) \le 0$ for all items; and $V_n(0,\delta') \le 0$, since for $\delta = 0$ the functional is a multiple of the trace (the canonical trace in items 11 and 24, where $\varphi(1) = n$).*

*Proof.* Item by item, with $|X| = x$, $|Y| = y$ scalar and $X = xU$, $Y = yV$ with unitaries (symmetries for self-adjoint $X, Y$), and $A = a$, $B = b$ scalars: (1) $|\varphi(U)| \le \varphi(1)$; (2) $\varphi(|xU+yV|) \le \|xU+yV\|\varphi(1) \le (x+y)\varphi(1)$; (3) and (4) as (1); (6) and (7) are equalities; (8) $|AB^*| = xy$ and $xy \le \frac{1}{2}(x^2+y^2)$; (10) and (25) follow from $a \le b$; (11) is an equality for $\varphi(1) = n$; (12) $\sqrt{a+b} \le \sqrt{a} + \sqrt{b}$; (13) $a + b - |a-b| = 2\min(a,b) \le 2\sqrt{ab}$; (16) is an equality; (24) $\varphi(a^2)^{1/2} = a\sqrt{n} \le an$. □

So a violation needs both contrasts: the functional must be far from a trace and the operators must be far from scalars. The next lemma is the mechanism behind the two-level operators: whenever the violation depends convexly on the spectrum of a variable, the extremal spectra have only two points.

**Lemma 2.5** (Vertex principle). *Fix all variables except the eigenvalues $\lambda \in [\ell', 1]^n$ of one positive variable (its eigenbasis fixed), and let $F(\lambda)$, $N(\lambda) > 0$ be the resulting values of $L - R$ and $N$. If $\lambda \mapsto F(\lambda) - cN(\lambda)$ is convex for every $c \in \mathbb{R}$, then the supremum of $F/N$ over the spectra with $\max_i \lambda_i = 1$ and $\min_i \lambda_i = \ell'$ equals its supremum over the two-level spectra $\lambda \in \{\ell', 1\}^n$ (both values occurring).*

*Proof.* The admissible set is the union of the faces $\{\lambda_i = 1,\ \lambda_j = \ell'\}$ of the cube, and the vertices of these faces are the two-level spectra. If $F/N > c$ at an admissible point, then $F - cN > 0$ there, and by convexity $F - cN > 0$ at a vertex of the same face, where therefore $F/N > c$. □

The hypothesis holds for Gardner's inequality ($F - cN = |\varphi(UT)| - (1 + c)\varphi(T)$ for $X = UT$: the modulus of a linear function minus a linear one), for item 3, for item 24 ($\varphi(A^2)^{1/2} = \|W^{1/2}A\|_2$ is a norm of a linear function of $\lambda$) and for the unnormalised Gardner violation of Section 4; for these items two-level operators suffice. For the other items we test numerically whether they do (Section 9).

## 3 The Kantorovich class

**Theorem 3.1.** *Let $W > 0$ in $M_n$, $n \geq 2$, and $\varphi = \varphi_W$. For all $X, Y, A$ and all projections $P, Q, R$,*

$$|\varphi(X)| \leq \kappa\,\varphi(|X|), \qquad \varphi(A + A^*) \leq 2\kappa\,\varphi(|A^*|), \qquad |\varphi(A^2)| \leq \kappa\,\varphi(A^*A),$$
$$\varphi(|X + Y|) \leq \kappa\big(\varphi(|X|) + \varphi(|Y|)\big), \qquad \varphi(|P - R|) \leq \kappa\big(\varphi(|P - Q|) + \varphi(|Q - R|)\big).$$

*All five constants are attained. Hence $V_n = \kappa - 1$ for items 1–5 in every dimension $n \geq 2$.*

*Proof.* Let $X = U|X|$ be a polar decomposition and $T = |X|$. Then $\varphi(X) = \mathrm{Tr}(WUT) = \mathrm{Tr}\big((WT^{1/2})^*UT^{1/2}\big)$, so for every contraction $U$

$$|\varphi(X)|^2 \leq \mathrm{Tr}(W^2T)\ \mathrm{Tr}\,T \leq \kappa^2(\mathrm{Tr}\,WT)^2$$

by the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality and Lemma 2.1 for $\omega = \mathrm{Tr}(T\,\cdot\,)$. The second inequality follows in the same way from $\varphi(A + A^*) = 2\mathrm{Re}\,\varphi(|A^*|V)$, where $A = |A^*|V$ is a polar decomposition. For the fourth, write $X + Y = S|X + Y|$; then $\varphi(|X + Y|) = \varphi(S^*X) + \varphi(S^*Y)$, and each term is bounded as above with the contraction $S^*U_X$ or $S^*U_Y$ in place of $U$. The fifth is the fourth with $X = P - Q$, $Y = Q - R$. For the third, put $X = AW^{1/2}$ in an eigenbasis of $W$ with eigenvalues $w_i$. Then $\varphi(A^*A) = \sum_{ij} |X_{ij}|^2$ and

$$\varphi(A^2) = \sum_i X_{ii}^2 + \sum_{i<j} X_{ij}X_{ji}\frac{w_i + w_j}{\sqrt{w_iw_j}}, \qquad \frac{w_i + w_j}{\sqrt{w_iw_j}} \leq 2\kappa,$$

so $|\varphi(A^2)| \leq \sum_i |X_{ii}|^2 + \kappa\sum_{i<j}(|X_{ij}|^2 + |X_{ji}|^2) \leq \kappa\varphi(A^*A)$.

Equality, with $e_1, e_2$ eigenvectors of $W$ for $a, b$: in the first two inequalities for $T = vv^*$ with $|\langle e_1, v\rangle|^2 = \frac{b}{a+b}$, $|\langle e_2, v\rangle|^2 = \frac{a}{a+b}$ and $Uv = Wv/\|Wv\|$ (equality in Cauchy–Schwarz and in Lemma 2.1); in the third for $A = \sqrt{a}\,e_1e_2^* + \sqrt{b}\,e_2e_1^*$; in the fourth for $X = uu^*$, $Y = -u'u'^*$ with $u, u' = \sin t\,e_1 \pm \cos t\,e_2$ and $\tan t = \sqrt{b/a}$; in the fifth for $P = uu^*$, $Q = 0$, $R = u'u'^*$. □

*Remark* 3.2. For a fixed density, $\sup_X |\varphi(X)|/\varphi(|X|) = \kappa(W)$ exactly. In particular the normalised violation of Gardner's inequality depends on $W$ only through its extreme eigenvalues, not on the dimension or on the rest of the spectrum.

## 4 Gardner's inequality with two contrasts

For Gardner's inequality both contrasts can be prescribed and the envelope found exactly. It depends on the two contrasts only through their product.

**Theorem 4.1.** *Let $W > 0$ and $X$ be in $M_n$, $n \geq 2$, with $\Delta(W) = \delta$ and $\Delta(|X|) = \delta'$, $\delta, \delta' \in [0,1]$, $\delta\delta' < 1$. Then*

$$|\varphi_W(X)| \leq \frac{1}{\sqrt{1-\delta^2\delta'^2}}\,\varphi_W(|X|),$$

*and for even $n$ the constant is attained: $V_n(\delta,\delta') = \kappa(\delta\delta') - 1 = (1-\delta^2\delta'^2)^{-1/2} - 1$ for Gardner's inequality. For odd $n = 2k+1$,*

$$V_n(\delta,\delta') = \max_{0\leq\gamma\leq 1} \frac{k\sqrt{S^2+\gamma pq} + \ell\ell'}{k(S+\gamma p) + \ell\ell'} - 1, \qquad S = \ell + \ell',\ q = (1+\ell)(1+\ell'),\ p = (1-\ell)(1-\ell'),$$

*with $\ell = \frac{1-\delta}{1+\delta}$, $\ell' = \frac{1-\delta'}{1+\delta'}$; it is smaller than $\kappa(\delta\delta') - 1$ for $\delta' < 1$ and tends to it as $n \to \infty$. For $\delta' = 1$ both give Theorem 3.1. The upper bound $\kappa(\delta\delta')$ holds also for items 2 and 3, with the contrasts of $|X|, |Y|$ and of $|A^*|$.*

*Proof.* Write $X = UT$ with $T = |X|$. The supremum of $|\operatorname{Tr}(WUT)| = |\operatorname{Tr}(U\,TW)|$ over unitaries $U$ is $\|TW\|_1$, so we must bound $\|TW\|_1/\operatorname{Tr}(TW)$. For fixed eigenbases, $\|TW\|_1 - c\operatorname{Tr}(TW)$ is a convex function of the eigenvalues of $T$ (a norm of a linear function minus a linear one), and likewise of the eigenvalues of $W$. By Lemma 2.5, applied to $T$ and then to $W$, we may assume $W = a(\ell + (1-\ell)P)$ and $T = t(\ell' + (1-\ell')Q)$ with projections $P, Q$ and $\ell = \frac{1-\delta}{1+\delta}$, $\ell' = \frac{1-\delta'}{1+\delta'}$. By Lemma 2.2, $\mathbb{C}^n$ splits into subspaces of dimension 1 or 2 invariant under $P$ and $Q$, hence under $W$ and $T$, and $\|TW\|_1$ and $\operatorname{Tr}(TW)$ are sums over them. On a one-dimensional summand the two contributions are equal. On a two-dimensional one, $W$ and $T$ have the eigenvalues $x_1, x_2$ and $y_1, y_2$, namely $a, a\ell$ and $t, t\ell'$; with $S = x_1y_2 + x_2y_1$, $q = (x_1+x_2)(y_1+y_2)$, $p = (x_1-x_2)(y_1-y_2)$ and $\gamma$ the squared overlap of the leading eigenvectors, the proof of Proposition 4.2 gives $\|TW\|_1^2 = S^2 + \gamma pq$ and $\operatorname{Tr}(TW) = S + \gamma p$. The function $\gamma \mapsto (S^2+\gamma pq)/(S+\gamma p)^2$ is maximal at $\gamma = S/q \in [0,1]$, with the value

$$\frac{q^2}{4S(S+p)} = \frac{(x_1+x_2)^2(y_1+y_2)^2}{4(x_1y_2+x_2y_1)(x_1y_1+x_2y_2)} = \frac{1}{1-\delta^2\delta'^2},$$

the last step by inserting $x_2/x_1 = \ell$, $y_2/y_1 = \ell'$. A quotient of sums is at most the largest quotient of the summands. Equality for even $n$: $n/2$ copies of the $2\times 2$ configuration $W = \operatorname{diag}(1,\ell)$, $T$ with the eigenvalues $1, \ell'$ at $\gamma = S/q$, and $U$ the adjoint polar factor of $TW$. For odd $n$ at least one summand is one-dimensional and contributes the same amount $m \geq \ell\ell'$ (normalising the largest eigenvalues of $W$ and $T$ to 1) to $\|TW\|_1$ and to $\operatorname{Tr}(TW)$; the quotient $(\sum_j L_j + m)/(\sum_j N_j + m)$ over at most $k$ two-dimensional summands with $L_j \geq N_j$ is largest for $k$ summands, $m = \ell\ell'$, and, by the argument of Lemma 2.5 applied to $L - cN$, the same $\gamma$ in every summand, which gives the stated maximum; it is attained by $W = \operatorname{diag}(1,\ell)^{\oplus k} \oplus \ell$ and $T$ correspondingly. Items 2 and 3 reduce to the first inequality as in the proof of Theorem 3.1. □

Thus the normalised violation of Gardner's inequality is $\frac{1}{2}\delta^2\delta'^2 + O(\delta^4\delta'^4)$: it vanishes to second order in each contrast and is symmetric in the density and the operator. The unnormalised violation studied in [1] behaves in the same way (Theorem 4.3 below).

In [1, Sect. 5] the violation of Gardner's inequality was studied without normalisation: for $X \geq 0$ with $\|X\| = 1$ (the density) and $Z$ with $\|Z\| = 1$, the quantity

$$z(X,Z) = |\operatorname{Tr}(XZ)| - \operatorname{Tr}(X|Z|)$$

was sampled against $\Delta(X)$ and $\Delta(|Z|)$. Writing $Z = U|Z|$ with a unitary (orthogonal, in the real case) $U$, $z = |\operatorname{Tr}(XUY)| - \operatorname{Tr}(XY)$ with $Y = |Z| \geq 0$, and $\sup_U z = \|YX\|_1 - \operatorname{Tr}(XY)$ by the duality of the trace norm, the supremum being attained at the polar unitary of $YX$, which is real if $X, Y$ are. We first solve the $2 \times 2$ case.

**Proposition 4.2.** *Let $X, Y \geq 0$ in $M_2(\mathbb{C})$ have eigenvalues $x_1 \geq x_2 \geq 0$ and $y_1 \geq y_2 \geq 0$, $x_1, y_1 > 0$. For every unitary $U$,*

$$|\operatorname{Tr}(XUY)| - \operatorname{Tr}(XY) \;\leq\; \frac{(x_1 - x_2)^2 (y_1 - y_2)^2}{4(x_1 + x_2)(y_1 + y_2)}.$$

*Let $S = x_1 y_2 + x_2 y_1$, $q = (x_1 + x_2)(y_1 + y_2)$, and $\gamma = |\langle e_1, f_1 \rangle|^2$ for unit eigenvectors $e_1$ of $X$ for $x_1$ and $f_1$ of $Y$ for $y_1$. If $x_1 > x_2$ and $y_1 > y_2$, the bound is attained iff $|\operatorname{Tr}(XUY)| = \|YX\|_1$ and $\gamma = \frac{1}{4} + \frac{S}{2q}$; it is attained by real $X, Y, U$.*

*Proof.* Let $p = (x_1 - x_2)(y_1 - y_2)$, so that $q - 2S = p$. First, $|\operatorname{Tr}(XUY)| = |\operatorname{Tr}(YXU)| \leq \|YX\|_1$. Expanding in the eigenbases, $\operatorname{Tr}(XY) = \sum_{ij} x_i y_j |\langle e_i, f_j \rangle|^2 = S + \gamma p$, since the matrix $(|\langle e_i, f_j \rangle|^2)$ is doubly stochastic. The singular values of $YX$ satisfy $s_1^2 + s_2^2 = \operatorname{Tr}(X^2 Y^2)$ and $s_1 s_2 = |\det YX| = x_1 x_2 y_1 y_2$, so $\|YX\|_1^2 = \operatorname{Tr}(X^2 Y^2) + 2 x_1 x_2 y_1 y_2 = S^2 + \gamma p q$. With $\sqrt{r} \leq r/q + q/4$ (equality iff $\sqrt{r} = q/2$),

$$\|YX\|_1 - \operatorname{Tr}(XY) \leq \frac{S^2 + \gamma p q}{q} + \frac{q}{4} - S - \gamma p = \frac{(q/2 - S)^2}{q} = \frac{p^2}{4q},$$

with equality iff $\gamma p q = q^2/4 - S^2 = \frac{p}{2}(\frac{q}{2} + S)$. Every $\gamma \in [0, 1]$ is realised by a real rotation, and the polar unitary of a real $YX$ is real. □

**Theorem 4.3.** *Let $\mathcal{M} = \bigoplus_{c=1}^{C} M_{k_c}(\mathbb{K})$, $\mathbb{K} \in \{\mathbb{R}, \mathbb{C}\}$, and $N = \sum_c \lfloor k_c/2 \rfloor \geq 1$. For $X \geq 0$ and $Y \geq 0$ in $\mathcal{M}$ with $\|X\| = \|Y\| = 1$, $\Delta(X) = \delta \in [0, 1)$ and $\Delta(Y) = \delta' \in [0, 1]$, and every unitary (orthogonal) $U \in \mathcal{M}$,*

$$|\operatorname{Tr}(XUY)| - \operatorname{Tr}(XY) \leq \frac{N\, \delta^2 \delta'^2}{(1 + \delta)(1 + \delta')},$$

*and the bound is attained. Equivalently, $\sup\{|\operatorname{Tr}(XZ)| - \operatorname{Tr}(X|Z|) : \|X\| = \|Z\| = 1,\ \Delta(X) = \delta,\ \Delta(|Z|) = \delta'\}$ has this value.*

*Proof.* Let $\ell = (1 - \delta)/(1 + \delta)$ and $\ell' = (1 - \delta')/(1 + \delta')$ be the smallest eigenvalues. It suffices to prove the bound in the complex algebra, since the maximisers below are real. By the remark above, $\sup_U z = F(X, Y) := \|YX\|_1 - \operatorname{Tr}(XY)$, and the polar unitary lies in $\mathcal{M}$. For a fixed eigenbasis of $X$, $F$ is a convex function of the eigenvalues of $X$ (a norm of a linear function of them minus a linear function). The admissible eigenvalues form the union of the faces $\{x_i = 1,\ x_j = \ell\}$ of the cube $[\ell, 1]^K$, $K = \sum_c k_c$, and a convex function on a face attains its maximum at a vertex; so $F(X, Y) \leq F(X', Y)$ for some $X' = \ell + (1 - \ell)P$ with a projection $P \in \mathcal{M}$, $P \neq 0, 1$, and likewise $F(X', Y) \leq F(X', Y')$ with $Y' = \ell' + (1 - \ell')Q$. By Lemma 2.2, applied in every block, $X'$ and $Y'$ are direct sums over subspaces of dimension 1 or 2, and so are $\|Y'X'\|_1$ and $\operatorname{Tr}(X'Y')$. One-dimensional summands contribute 0. On a two-dimensional one, $X' = \operatorname{diag}(1, \ell)$ and $Y'$ has the eigenvalues $1, \ell'$, so by Proposition 4.2 it contributes at most $(1 - \ell)^2 (1 - \ell')^2 / (4(1 + \ell)(1 + \ell')) = \delta^2 \delta'^2 / ((1 + \delta)(1 + \delta'))$. A block of size $k_c$ holds at most $\lfloor k_c/2 \rfloor$ two-dimensional summands. Equality: $N$ blocks $\operatorname{diag}(1, \ell)$ and $Y$ with spectrum $\{1, \ell'\}$ at the angle of Proposition 4.2, $X = Y = 1$ on the remaining one-dimensional blocks, and the polar unitary, which makes all block traces positive. □

*Remark* 4.4. (i) With the contrast of $|Z|$ free, the supremum $N\delta^2/(2(1 + \delta))$ is reached at $\delta' = 1$, i.e. for singular $Z$. (ii) The bound is additive over the blocks: it counts the mutually orthogonal two-dimensional subspaces that fit into the blocks, and it does not depend on the sizes of the blocks

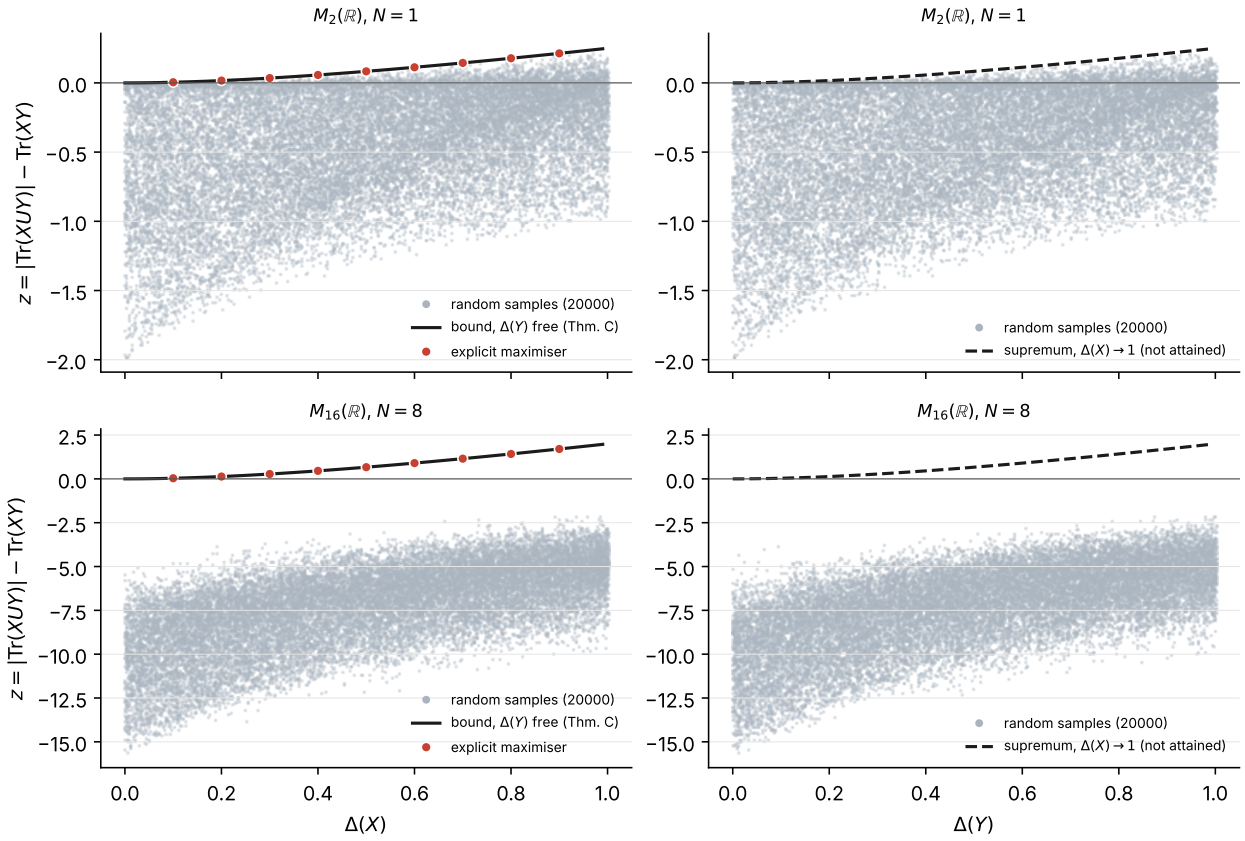



Figure 1: The unnormalised Gardner violation $z = |\operatorname{Tr}(XUY)| - \operatorname{Tr}(XY)$ for $\|X\| = \|Y\| = 1$ in $M_2(\mathbb{R})$ (top, $N = 1$) and $M_{16}(\mathbb{R})$ (bottom, $N = 8$), against $\Delta(X)$ (left) and $\Delta(Y)$ (right). Grey: 20000 random samples with Haar-orthogonal eigenbases and $U$ and uniformly drawn contrasts, as in [1, Fig. 1]. Solid: the bound of Theorem 4.3 with $\Delta(Y)$ free, $N\delta^2/(2(1+\delta))$; dots: $z$ at the explicit maximisers of its proof, which agree with it to $10^{-15}$. Dashed: the supremum along $\Delta(Y)$, approached as $\Delta(X) \to 1$. In $M_{16}$ no sample violates Gardner's inequality ($z > 0$), although violations up to almost 2 exist: the maximisers, two-level spectra on aligned pairs of eigenvectors, form a set of negligible Haar measure. Computed with plain NumPy by `scripts/trace_envelopes_figures.py`.

otherwise. (iii) The normalised version is Theorem 3.1: $\sup_Z |\operatorname{Tr}(XZ)|/\operatorname{Tr}(X|Z|) = \kappa(X)$, attained by a rank-one $|Z|$, i.e. at $\Delta(|Z|) = 1$. The unnormalised supremum vanishes to fourth order at $\delta = \delta' = 0$ because the violation needs both operators to be far from scalar. (iv) Figures 1 and 2 compare the bound with random sampling and with numerical optimisation. Sampling, the method of [1], stays far below the bound as soon as the blocks are larger than $2 \times 2$, while the optimisation over both contrasts reproduces it.

## 5 Young, Bikchentaev–Abed and the canonical trace

**Proposition 5.1.** *$\varphi_W(|AB^*|) \le h \cdot \frac{1}{2}\big(\varphi_W(|A|^2) + \varphi_W(|B|^2)\big)$ for all $A, B$, with equality for $A = B = e_1e_2^*$. Hence $V_n = h - 1 = 2\delta/(1-\delta)$ for item 8 in every dimension.*

*Proof.* $\varphi_W(|AB^*|) \le a\|AB^*\|_1 \le a\|A\|_2\|B\|_2$ and $\varphi_W(|A|^2) = \operatorname{Tr}(WA^*A) \ge b\|A\|_2^2$. For $A = B = e_1e_2^*$, $|AB^*| = e_1e_1^*$ and $|A|^2 = e_2e_2^*$, so $L = a$ and $R = b$. □

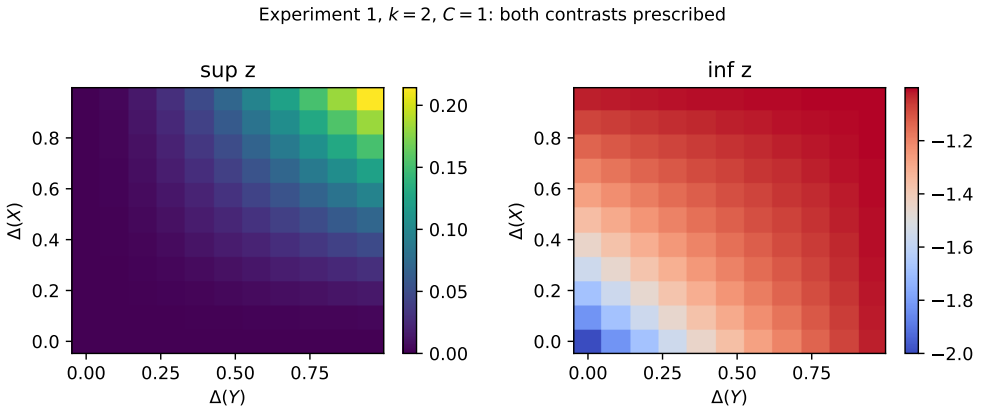



Figure 2: $M_2(\mathbb{R})$, both contrasts prescribed: the supremum (left) and infimum (right) of $z = |\operatorname{Tr}(XUY)| - \operatorname{Tr}(XY)$ found by constrained optimisation on a grid of $\Delta(Y)$ (horizontal) and $\Delta(X)$ (vertical). The left panel agrees with $\delta^2\delta'^2/((1+\delta)(1+\delta'))$ (Theorem 4.3) to $5 \times 10^{-10}$ at every grid point: a violation needs both operators to be far from scalar.

*Remark* 5.2. For the published form with $A, B \geq 0$ an independent numerical search ($n = 2, 3$) gives only $V \approx \kappa - 1$ (0.1546 at $\delta = 0.5$ and 1.294 at $\delta = 0.9$, against $\kappa - 1 = 0.1547$ and 1.294). The linear failure of item 8 is a feature of the extension to arbitrary operators.

**Proposition 5.3.** *Let $\Delta(W) = \delta$ and let the moduli of $A$ and $B$ have contrast $\delta'$. For $n = 2$ (and, by direct sums, for every even $n$) the extended Young inequality has*

$$V_n(\delta, \delta') \;\geq\; \frac{h + \ell'^2}{1 + h\ell'^2} - 1 = \frac{4\delta\delta'}{1 + \delta'^2 - 2\delta\delta'}, \qquad \ell' = \frac{1 - \delta'}{1 + \delta'},$$

*attained by $A = B = UT$ with $T = \operatorname{diag}(\ell', 1)$ in the eigenbasis of $W = \operatorname{diag}(a, b)$ and $U$ the swap of the two basis vectors. For $\delta' = 1$ this is Proposition 5.1.*

*Proof.* For $A = B$, $|AB^*| = |AA^*| = AA^* = UT^2U^* = \operatorname{diag}(1, \ell'^2)$ and $|A|^2 = T^2 = \operatorname{diag}(\ell'^2, 1)$, so $L = a + b\ell'^2$ and $R = a\ell'^2 + b$, and $L/R = (h + \ell'^2)/(h\ell'^2 + 1)$. Inserting $h = \frac{1+\delta}{1-\delta}$ and $\ell'$ gives the second form. □

The certified search over all $A, B$ with this contrast reproduces the bound to four digits on $M_2$ (Figure 3); we conjecture equality for even $n$. Unlike Gardner's inequality, the extended Young inequality fails *linearly* in each contrast, $V \sim 4\delta\delta'$.

**Proposition 5.4.** *For $n = 2$, item 9 has the envelope $V_2 = s/(1 + s)$, $s = \sin(\psi/2)$. Thus $V_2 \sim \delta/2$ as $\delta \to 0$ and $V_2 \to \sqrt{2} - 1$ as $\delta \to 1$.*

*Proof.* If $P$ or $Q$ is 0 or 1, or $P = Q$, then $L = R$. Otherwise $P = uu^*$, $Q = vv^*$ with unit vectors; choose phases so that $u = cv + \sigma v_\perp$ with $c = \cos\theta$, $\sigma = \sin\theta$, $0 < \theta < \pi/2$, and a unit vector $v_\perp \perp v$. Normalise $\operatorname{Tr} W = 2$, so that $W$ has the eigenvalues $1 \pm \delta$, and put $\beta = v^*Wv$, $\gamma = v_\perp^*Wv_\perp = 2 - \beta$, $t = \operatorname{Re}(v^*Wv_\perp)$ and $\rho = |v^*Wv_\perp|$; then $\beta\gamma - \rho^2 = \det W = 1 - \delta^2$. Since $PQ + QP = c(uv^* + vu^*)$ and $QPQ = c^2Q$,

$$L - R = 2c\operatorname{Re}(v^*Wu) - 2c^2\beta = 2c\sigma t, \qquad N = u^*Wu + \beta = \beta(1 + c^2) + \sigma^2\gamma + 2c\sigma t.$$

With $D = \beta(1+c^2) + \sigma^2\gamma > 0$ the quotient $2c\sigma t/(D + 2c\sigma t)$ increases with $t \le \rho$, so it is at most $r/(1+r)$ with

$$r = \frac{2c\sigma\rho}{D} = \frac{\rho \sin 2\theta}{\beta + 1 + (\beta - 1)\cos 2\theta} \le \frac{\rho}{\sqrt{(\beta+1)^2 - (\beta-1)^2}} = \frac{\rho}{2\sqrt{\beta}},$$

using $\gamma = 2 - \beta$ and $\max_x \sin x/(p + q\cos x) = (p^2 - q^2)^{-1/2}$ for $p > |q|$. Finally $r^2 \le \rho^2/(4\beta) = \frac{1}{4}\big(2 - \beta - (1-\delta^2)/\beta\big)$, which is maximal at $\beta = \sqrt{1-\delta^2} = \cos\psi$ with the value $\frac{1}{2}(1 - \cos\psi) = \sin^2(\psi/2)$. All steps are equalities for $v$ with $v^*Wv = \cos\psi$, a phase of $v_\perp$ with $v^*Wv_\perp = \rho > 0$, and the optimal $\theta$, and $r \mapsto r/(1+r)$ is increasing. □

**Proposition 5.5.** *Let* $\operatorname{Tr} W = n$. *For item 11,* $V(W) = 1 - \mathrm{GM/AM}$ *of the eigenvalues of* $W$, *attained at* $A = W^{-1}$. *Over the densities with contrast* $\delta$ *the maximum is attained at a two-level spectrum:*

$$V_n(\delta) = 1 - \min_{1 \le m < n} \frac{n\,\ell^{(n-m)/n}}{m + (n-m)\ell}, \qquad \ell = \frac{1}{h} = \frac{1-\delta}{1+\delta}.$$

*In particular* $V_2 = 1 - \sqrt{1-\delta^2}$, *and* $V_n \uparrow 1 - 1/S(h)$ *as* $n \to \infty$, *where* $S(h) = \frac{(h-1)h^{1/(h-1)}}{e \log h}$ *is the Specht ratio.*

*Proof.* By the AM–GM inequality for the eigenvalues of $W^{1/2}AW^{1/2}$, $\varphi_W(A)/n \ge (\det W \det A)^{1/n}$, with equality for $A = W^{-1}$, so $\inf_{A>0} \varphi_W(A)/(n(\det A)^{1/n}) = (\det W)^{1/n}$ and $V(W) = 1 - (\det W)^{1/n}$, which for $\operatorname{Tr} W = n$ is $1 - \mathrm{GM/AM}$. In the coordinates $x_i = \log w_i$, $\mathrm{AM/GM} = \frac{1}{n}\sum_i e^{x_i - \bar{x}}$ is convex, so on the box of spectra in $[b, a]$ it is maximal at a vertex, a two-level spectrum with $m$ eigenvalues $a$ and $n - m$ eigenvalues $b$; this gives the formula. Its limit is Specht's theorem [29]: $\sup \mathrm{AM/GM}$ over all finite families in $[b, a]$ is $S(h)$. □

**Proposition 5.6.** *Let* $\operatorname{Tr} W = n$. *For item 24,* $V(W) = w_{\min}^{-1/2} - 1$, *and*

$$V_n(\delta) = \sqrt{\frac{\ell + n - 1}{n\ell}} - 1, \qquad \ell = \frac{1-\delta}{1+\delta};$$

$V_2 = (1-\delta)^{-1/2} - 1 \sim \delta/2$, $V_n \sim \frac{n-1}{n}\delta$, *and* $V_n \uparrow \sqrt{h} - 1$ *as* $n \to \infty$.

*Proof.* For $A \ge 0$, $\varphi(A^2) = \operatorname{Tr}(A^{1/2}WA^{1/2}A) \le \|A\|\varphi(A) \le \operatorname{Tr}(A)\varphi(A) \le \varphi(A)^2/w_{\min}$, with equality for the projection onto an eigenvector for $w_{\min}$. With $\operatorname{Tr} W = n$ and the extreme eigenvalues in the ratio $h$, $w_{\min} = nb/\sum_i w_i \ge nb/(b + (n-1)a) = n\ell/(\ell + n - 1)$, with equality for the spectrum $\{a, \dots, a, b\}$. For $n = 2$, $(\ell+1)/(2\ell) = 1/(1-\delta)$. □

*Remark* 5.7. Items 11 and 24 characterise the canonical trace among the functionals with $\varphi(1) = n$, so they are violated also by central densities on a direct sum (Section 8), and their envelopes grow with $n$, unlike all others with a closed form.

## 6 Inequalities for two projections

**Theorem 6.1.** *Let* $W > 0$ *in* $M_n$, $n \ge 2$, *with* $\Delta(W) = \delta$, *and let* $P, Q$ *be projections. With* $N$ *as in Table 1:*

*(17)* $V_n = \kappa^2 - 1$ *for* $\varphi(PQP) \le \varphi(Q)$;

*(18)* $V_n = \kappa - 1$ *for* $\varphi(|P - Q|) \le \varphi(P + Q)$;

*(19)* $V_n = \delta$ *for* $\varphi(P+Q) \le \varphi(1+P\wedge Q)$ *if* $n$ *is even, and* $V_n = (n-1)\delta/(n-\delta)$ *if* $n$ *is odd;*

*(20) for* $\varphi(e^{QPQ}) \le \varphi(e^P)$ *and even* $n$, $V_n = \max_{0<g<\pi} \lambda(\delta, g)$, *where* $\lambda(\delta, g)$ *is the larger root of the quadratic* (2) *below, and* $V_n = \frac{(e-1)^2}{e(e+1)}\delta^2 + O(\delta^3)$;

*(21)* $V_n = \frac{1}{2}\tan^2(\psi/2)$ *for* $\varphi(\operatorname{Re} PQ) \ge 0$;

*(22)* $V_n = \kappa - 1$ *for* $\varphi(\operatorname{Re} PQ) \le \varphi(|PQ|)$;

*(23)* $V_n = \delta/(1-\delta)$ *for* $\varphi(P\vee Q) \le \varphi(P) + \varphi(Q)$.

*The values are attained in 17, 18, 20–22 by rank-one* $P, Q$, *and approached in 19 and 23 as* $P \ne Q$ *tend to the same eigenvector of* $W$. *For odd* $n$, $V_n$ *in item 20 lies between the* $M_2$ *value and the same maximum with* $(1-\delta)/(n-1)$ *added to* $\beta$ *in* (2).

*Proof. Step 1: reduction to rank-one projections on* $M_2$. By Lemma 2.2, $\mathbb{C}^n = \bigoplus_j H_j$ with $\dim H_j \in \{1, 2\}$, every $H_j$ invariant under $P$ and $Q$. Every operator in $L$, $R$ and $N$ (namely $PQP$, $Q$, $|P-Q|$, $P+Q$, $1+P\wedge Q$, $e^{QPQ}$, $e^P$, $\operatorname{Re} PQ$, $|PQ|$, $P\vee Q$) is then block diagonal, with the block obtained from $P_j, Q_j$; for the lattice operations because $\operatorname{ran} P \cap \operatorname{ran} Q = \bigoplus_j (\operatorname{ran} P_j \cap \operatorname{ran} Q_j)$, the projections onto the $H_j$ commuting with $P$ and $Q$. Hence $L = \sum_j L_j$, $R = \sum_j R_j$ and $N = \sum_j N_j$, where $L_j$ is the same expression for $P_j, Q_j$ and the functional $\operatorname{Tr}(W_j \cdot)$ on $H_j$, with the compression $W_j$ of $W$ to $H_j$; its spectrum lies in $[b, a]$, so $\Delta(W_j) \le \delta$. On a one-dimensional $H_j$, $P_j, Q_j \in \{0, 1\}$ commute and $L_j \le R_j$ in all seven items (e.g. $\max(p,q) \le p+q$, $p+q \le 1+pq$, $e^{pq} \le e^p$). On a two-dimensional $H_j$, $P_j \ne Q_j$ are rank-one projections. Since $N_j \ge 0$, and $L_j \le R_j$ wherever $N_j = 0$,

$$\frac{L-R}{N} \le \max_j \frac{L_j - R_j}{N_j},$$

and the quotients do not change when $W_j$ is scaled. It therefore suffices to bound $(L-R)/N$ for $W = \frac{1}{2}(1+\tau\sigma_3)$, $0 \le \tau \le \delta$, and $P = \frac{1}{2}(1+\mu\cdot\sigma)$, $Q = \frac{1}{2}(1+\nu\cdot\sigma)$ with unit Bloch vectors $\mu \ne \nu$ in $\mathbb{R}^3$ ($\sigma = (\sigma_1, \sigma_2, \sigma_3)$ the Pauli matrices). For fixed $\mu, \nu$ the quotient is a linear-fractional function of $\tau$ (all three quantities are affine in $W$) with positive denominator, hence monotone on $[-\delta, \delta]$; conjugation by $\sigma_1$ maps $\tau$ to $-\tau$ and $(\mu, \nu)$ to reflected vectors. So the bound for $\tau = \delta$ covers every $\tau \le \delta$, and the $M_2$ envelope bounds the envelope in every dimension. In 17, 18 and 21–23, $N$ vanishes on blocks where $P = Q = 0$, so the values below, attained (or approached) on $M_2$, are attained (approached) on $M_n$ with $P, Q$ supported on the span of $e_1, e_2$. In 19 and 20, $N$ contains $\varphi(1)$, which we treat at the end.

*Step 2: formulas on* $M_2$. Write $\varphi(x_0 + x\cdot\sigma) = x_0 + \delta x_3$, $\mu\cdot\nu = \cos 2\theta$ $(0 < \theta \le \pi/2)$ and $c = \cos\theta = |\langle u, v\rangle|$ for unit vectors $u, v$ with $P = uu^*$, $Q = vv^*$. Then $PQP = c^2 P$, $(P-Q)^2 = \sin^2\theta \cdot 1$, $P\wedge Q = 0$, $P\vee Q = 1$, $\operatorname{Re} PQ = \frac{1}{4}(1 + \mu\cdot\nu + (\mu+\nu)\cdot\sigma)$, $|PQ| = (QPQ)^{1/2} = cQ$, $e^{QPQ} = 1 + (e^{c^2} - 1)Q$, $e^P = 1 + (e-1)P$, and $|\mu + \nu| = 2\cos\theta$. We use the following elementary fact: *for* $\beta > |z|$, $\max_{|\xi|=1}(\alpha + y\cdot\xi)/(\beta + z\cdot\xi)$ *is the unique zero* $\lambda$ *of* $\alpha - \lambda\beta + |y - \lambda z|$, since $(\alpha + y\cdot\xi) - \lambda(\beta + z\cdot\xi) \le \alpha - \lambda\beta + |y - \lambda z|$ with equality for $\xi \parallel y - \lambda z$, and the right-hand side decreases strictly in $\lambda$.

(17) $L/R = (1+\mu\cdot\nu)(1+\delta\mu_3)/(2(1+\delta\nu_3))$. For fixed $\mu$, the fact with $\alpha = \beta = 1$, $y = \mu$, $z = \delta e_3$ gives $\max_\nu (1+\mu\cdot\nu)/(1+\delta\nu_3) = 2(1-\delta\mu_3)/(1-\delta^2)$, so $L/R \le (1-\delta^2\mu_3^2)/(1-\delta^2) \le \kappa^2$, with equality for $\mu_3 = 0$ and $\nu = (\mu - \lambda\delta e_3)/(\lambda - 1)$, $\lambda = 2/(1-\delta^2)$.

(18) $L/R = \sin\theta/(1 + \frac{\delta}{2}(\mu_3 + \nu_3)) \le \sin\theta/(1 - \delta\cos\theta) \le \kappa$, the maximum being at $\cos\theta = \delta$, $\mu + \nu \parallel -e_3$. (Alternatively, $\varphi(|P-Q|) \le \kappa\varphi(P+Q)$ is the triangle inequality of Theorem 3.1 with $X = P$, $Y = -Q$.)

(19) $(L-R)/N = \varphi(P+Q) - 1 = \frac{\delta}{2}(\mu_3 + \nu_3) < \delta$, approached as $\mu, \nu \to e_3$.

(20) For fixed $g = 2\theta$, the pair $(\mu_3, \nu_3)$ ranges over the image of the unit sphere under $\xi \mapsto (\mu\cdot\xi, \nu\cdot\xi)$, a filled ellipse, and the linear-fractional quotient is maximal on its boundary, $\mu_3 = \cos x$, $\nu_3 = \cos(x+g)$. With $K = e-1$ and $E = e^{\cos^2(g/2)} - 1$,

$$\frac{L-R}{N} = \frac{\alpha + y\cdot\xi_x}{\beta + z\cdot\xi_x}, \quad \alpha = \tfrac{E-K}{2},\ y = \tfrac{\delta}{2}(E\cos g - K,\ -E\sin g),\ \beta = 1+\tfrac{K}{2},\ z = (\tfrac{\delta K}{2}, 0),$$

$\xi_x = (\cos x, \sin x)$. By the fact, its maximum $\lambda(\delta, g)$ is the larger root of

$$(\beta^2 - |z|^2)\lambda^2 - 2(\alpha\beta - y\cdot z)\lambda + \alpha^2 - |y|^2 = 0. \tag{2}$$

For small $\delta$ the maximiser has $g = 2K\delta/e + O(\delta^2)$, $x = \pi/2$, and $L - R = -\frac{e}{8}g^2 + \frac{K\delta}{2}g + O(\delta^3)$, which gives $V = K^2\delta^2/(e(e+1)) + O(\delta^3)$.

(21) With $s = \mu_3 + \nu_3 \geq -2\cos\theta$, $(L-R)/N = -(2\cos^2\theta + \delta s)/(4(1+\frac{\delta}{2}s))$, which decreases in $s$; so $(L-R)/N \leq (\delta C - C^2)/(2(1-\delta C))$, $C = \cos\theta$. The maximum over $C$ is at $\delta C^2 - 2C + \delta = 0$, $C = \tan(\psi/2)$, with the value $C^2/2 = \frac{1}{2}\tan^2(\psi/2)$.

(22) $\varphi(\operatorname{Re} PQ) = \operatorname{Re}\varphi(PQ) \leq |\varphi(PQ)| \leq \kappa\varphi(|PQ|)$ by Theorem 3.1, in every dimension. Equality: $v = \sqrt{b/(a+b)}\,e_1 + \sqrt{a/(a+b)}\,e_2$, $u = Wv/\|Wv\|$; then $PQ = \langle u, v\rangle uv^*$ has the polar factor of the equality case of Theorem 3.1.

(23) $L/R = 1/(1+\frac{\delta}{2}(\mu_3+\nu_3)) < 1/(1-\delta)$, approached as $\mu, \nu \to -e_3$.

*Step 3: items 19 and 20 in dimension n.* For even $n$ take $W$ with the eigenvalues $a$ and $b$, each $n/2$ times, and $n/2$ copies of the $M_2$ extremiser, one in each block spanned by an eigenvector for $a$ and one for $b$; this attains (approaches) the $M_2$ value, which is an upper bound by Step 1. For odd $n$ at least one block of Lemma 2.2 is one-dimensional, so there are $k' \leq k = (n-1)/2$ two-dimensional blocks. In item 19, $N \geq \varphi(1) = \operatorname{Tr} W$; by Step 2 a two-dimensional block contributes $L_j - R_j = \operatorname{Tr} W_j \cdot \frac{\Delta(W_j)}{2}(\mu_3+\nu_3) < \lambda_1(W_j) - \lambda_2(W_j)$, and a one-dimensional one $L_j - R_j \leq 0$. By Ky Fan's maximum principle [3, Sect. III.1], $\sum_j \lambda_1(W_j)$ is at most the sum of the $k'$ largest and $\sum_j \lambda_2(W_j)$ at least the sum of the $k'$ smallest eigenvalues of $W$. The resulting bound for $(L-R)/N$ is a linear-fractional function of the spectrum of $W$ and is maximal for $k' = k$ and the spectrum $a^{(k)}, b^{(k+1)}$; hence $(L-R)/N < k(a-b)/(k(a+b)+b) = (n-1)\delta/(n-\delta)$, which is approached for this spectrum with $P = 1$, $Q = 0$ on the remaining eigenvector (a block with $L_j = R_j$). In item 20 the same configuration, with $P = Q = 0$ on the remaining eigenvector, adds $b/k$ per block to $N$, i.e. $(1-\delta)/(n-1)$ to $\beta$ (normalisation $\operatorname{Tr} W_j = 1$); this gives the lower bound, and the $M_2$ value the upper bound. □

# 7 Lower bounds

**Proposition 7.1.** *For every $n \geq 2$:*

*(a) $V_n \geq \kappa - 1$ for item 6 (approached);*

*(b) $V_n \geq \kappa^2 - 1 = \delta^2/(1-\delta^2)$ for item 7 (approached);*

*(c) $V_n \geq m(\delta) := \max_{0<y<\delta} \dfrac{y^2(\delta-y)^2}{(1-2\delta y+y^2)(1-y^2)} = \dfrac{\delta^4}{16} + O(\delta^5)$ for item 10 (attained);*

*(d) $V_n \geq \delta^2/36 + O(\delta^3)$ for item 14, and more generally $(1-\frac{2}{p})^2\delta^2/4 + O(\delta^3)$ for Hölder's inequality $|\varphi(PQ)| \leq \varphi(P)^{1/p}\varphi(Q)^{1/q}$.*

*By Lemma 2.3, $V_n \leq h - 1$ in (a)–(c).*

*Proof.* All constructions live on $\operatorname{span}\{e_1, e_2\}$ (extended by 0, or by a small multiple of the identity where positive definiteness is required); let $e_\pm = (e_1 \pm e_2)/\sqrt{2}$.

(a) For invertible $A$ and a rank-one $B = vv^*$, $\|v\| = 1$, we have $A^{-1}\#vv^* = (v^*Av)^{-1/2}vv^*$, hence $(A^{-1}\#B)^{1/2} = (v^*Av)^{-1/4}vv^*$ and $A\natural B = (v^*Av)^{1/2}vv^*$. With $v = e_+$ and $A = xx^* + \varepsilon$,

$$\frac{\varphi(A\natural B)^2}{\varphi(A)\varphi(B)} = \frac{(v^*Av)(v^*Wv)}{\operatorname{Tr}(WA)} \xrightarrow[\varepsilon\to 0]{} \frac{|v^*x|^2\, v^*Wv}{x^*Wx},$$

which for $x = W^{-1}v$ equals $(v^*W^{-1}v)(v^*Wv) = \frac{1}{4}(a^{-1}+b^{-1})(a+b) = \kappa^2$. By continuity the quotient $L/R$ approaches $\kappa$ for positive definite $A$, $B = vv^* + \varepsilon'$.

(b) In the basis $f_1 = e_+$, $f_2 = e_-$ the density has the entries $W_{11} = W_{22} = \frac{a+b}{2}$, $W_{12} = \frac{a-b}{2}$. Take $B = \eta f_1 f_1^* + f_2 f_2^*$ and $A = uu^*$ with $u = f_1 + s\eta f_2$. Then $B^{1/2}AB^{1/2} = ww^*$ with $w = \sqrt{\eta} f_1 + s\eta f_2$, so $L = \|w\|^2\, w^*Ww = \eta^2 W_{11} + O(\eta^{5/2})$, and $Bu = \eta(f_1 + sf_2)$, so $R = \|u\|^2\eta^2(W_{11} + 2sW_{12} + s^2W_{22})$. As $\eta \to 0$, $L/R \to W_{11}/(W_{11} + 2sW_{12} + s^2W_{22})$, which at $s = -W_{12}/W_{22}$ equals $W_{11}W_{22}/(W_{11}W_{22} - W_{12}^2) = (a+b)^2/(4ab) = \kappa^2$.

(c) Normalise $a + b = 2$, so $W = \operatorname{diag}(1+\delta, 1-\delta)$, and take $A = uu^*$, $B = A + tvv^*$, $t \ge 0$, with $u = (\cos\alpha, \sin\alpha)$, $v = (-\cos\alpha, \sin\alpha)$ and $y = -\cos 2\alpha$. Then $u^*v = y$, $v^*Wu = y - \delta$ and $u^*Wu = v^*Wv = 1 - \delta y$, so

$$L - R = \varphi(A^2) - \varphi(B^2) = -2t\operatorname{Re}\big((u^*v)(v^*Wu)\big) - t^2 v^*Wv = 2ty(\delta - y) - t^2(1 - \delta y).$$

For $0 < y < \delta$ the best $t = y(\delta - y)/(1 - \delta y) > 0$ gives $L - R = G := y^2(\delta - y)^2/(1 - \delta y)$ and $(L - R)/R = G/(1 - \delta y - G) = y^2(\delta - y)^2/((1 - 2\delta y + y^2)(1 - y^2))$. Maximising over $y$ gives $m(\delta)$; the leading order comes from $y = \delta/2$.

(d) Take $W = \frac{1}{2}(1 + \delta D)$, $D = \operatorname{diag}(1, -1)$, and real unit vectors $u, v$ at the angles $m \pm \varepsilon/2$ to $e_1$, $P = uu^*$, $Q = vv^*$. Then $\varphi(PQ) = \frac{1}{2}(\cos^2\varepsilon + \delta\cos\varepsilon\cos 2m)$ and $\varphi(P)^{1/p}\varphi(Q)^{1/q} = \frac{1}{2}\big(1 + \delta\cos 2m + \delta(\frac{1}{q} - \frac{1}{p})\varepsilon\sin 2m\big) + O(\delta^2\varepsilon^2)$, so $L - R = \frac{1}{2}\big(-\varepsilon^2 - \delta(1 - \frac{2}{p})\varepsilon\sin 2m\big) + O(\delta^3)$ for $\varepsilon = O(\delta)$. The choice $m = \pi/4$, $\varepsilon = -\frac{\delta}{2}(1 - \frac{2}{p})$ gives $L - R = \frac{1}{8}(1 - \frac{2}{p})^2\delta^2 + O(\delta^3)$ and $R = \frac{1}{2} + O(\delta)$. □

**Proposition 7.2.** *For item 25 ($\varphi(A^4) \le \varphi(AB^2A)$ for $0 \le A \le B$), rank-one $A$ gives no violation, and an explicit construction with $A$ of rank two and $B - A$ of rank one gives*

$$V_n \ge m_{25}(\delta) = \frac{\delta^8}{4096}\big(1 + O(\delta^2)\big) \qquad \text{in every dimension } n \ge 2.$$

*Proof.* If $A = \alpha uu^*$ has rank one and $A \le B$, then $u^*Bu \ge \alpha$ and $AB^2A = \alpha^2\|Bu\|^2uu^* \ge \alpha^2(u^*Bu)^2uu^* \ge A^4$, so every positive $\varphi$ satisfies the inequality. For the construction take $W$ with $\operatorname{Tr} W = 1$ and eigenvalues $(1 \pm \delta)/2$, and, in an orthonormal basis at the angle $\vartheta$ to its eigenbasis, $A = \operatorname{diag}(1, s)$, $0 < s < 1$, and $B = A + tvv^*$ with $v = (\cos\phi, \sin\phi)$; in this basis $W$ has the entries $w_{11,22} = \frac{1}{2}(1 \pm \delta\cos 2\vartheta)$ and $w_{12} = \frac{\delta}{2}\sin 2\vartheta$. Then $R - L = tT_1 + t^2T_2$ with $T_1 = \varphi(A^2P_vA + AP_vA^2)$, $T_2 = \varphi(AP_vA)$, $P_v = vv^*$, and whenever $T_1 < 0$ the best $t = -T_1/(2T_2)$ gives $(L - R)/R = G/(L - G)$, $G = T_1^2/(4T_2)$. Let $m_{25}(\delta)$ be the maximum over $(\vartheta, s, \phi)$; it is attained, and by embedding $\mathbb{C}^2 \subset \mathbb{C}^n$ (with $A$, $B$ extended by 0) it is a lower bound in every dimension. For the leading order put $\vartheta = \pi/4$, $\sqrt{s} = \sigma\delta$ and $\tan\phi = -\varrho s^{-3/2}$. Then $T_1 = \cos^2\phi\,(1 + \varrho^2 - (1 + s)\varrho/\sigma)$, $T_2 = \cos^2\phi\,(\frac{1}{2} + \frac{\varrho^2}{2s} - \frac{\varrho}{\sigma})$ and $\cos^2\phi = s^3/(s^3 + \varrho^2)$, so that

$$\frac{L - R}{R} = \big(\sigma^2(\varsigma - \varsigma^2) - \sigma^4\big)^2\delta^8 + O(\delta^{10}), \qquad \varsigma = \sigma/\varrho,$$

which is maximal for $\varsigma = \frac{1}{2}$, $\sigma^2 = \frac{1}{8}$, with the value $\delta^8/4096$. □

The numerical maximisation gives $m_{25}(0.1)/(0.1^8/4096) = 1.020$. The same scaling for a general exponent $r \geq 0$ in $\varphi(A^{2r+2}) \leq \varphi(A^r B^2 A^r)$ gives the order $\delta^{4(r+1)}$; for $r = 0$ the supremum of the leading coefficient is $\frac{1}{16}$, that of item 10.

*Remark* 7.3. With $N = R$, item 13 would have $V = \infty$ for every $\delta > 0$: for rank-one $A = uu^*$, $B = vv^*$ with overlap $c = |u^*v| \to 0$, $L \approx 2c\,|u^*Wu_\perp|$ while $R = 2c^2 u^*Wu$. This is why we normalise by $\varphi(A+B)$.

## 8 Direct sums: only the contrast inside the blocks matters

Let $\mathcal{M} = \bigoplus_{c=1}^{C} M_{k_c}$, with the trace $\mathrm{Tr} = \sum_c \mathrm{Tr}_c$ and $\varphi_W = \mathrm{Tr}(W\,\cdot)$, $W = \bigoplus_c W_c \geq 0$. The traces on $\mathcal{M}$ are the functionals $\sum_c t_c \,\mathrm{Tr}_c$, $t_c \geq 0$; so $\varphi_W$ is a trace iff $W$ is central, whatever its global contrast. The global contrast $\Delta(W)$ thus says nothing about traciality, and the following theorem shows that it says nothing about the size of the violation either.

**Theorem 8.1.** *Let $W = \bigoplus_c W_c > 0$ in $\mathcal{M}$, and let $V_{\mathcal{M}}(W)$ and $V_{M_{k_c}}(W_c)$ be the suprema of the normalised violation of one inequality of Table 1, other than 11, 16 and 24, for $\varphi_W$ on $\mathcal{M}$ and for $\varphi_{W_c}$ on $M_{k_c}$. Then*

$$V_{\mathcal{M}}(W) \leq \max_c V_{M_{k_c}}(W_c),$$

*with equality for items 1–10, 12–14, 17, 18, 21–23 and 25. In particular, if every $W_c$ is scalar, no inequality of Table 1 except 11 and 24 is violated, however different the scalars are; and the envelope on $\mathcal{M}$ along the intra-block contrast $\max_c \Delta(W_c) = \delta$ is at most the largest envelope $V_{k_c}(\delta)$ of the blocks.*

*Proof.* All variables of the items are in $\mathcal{M}$, hence block diagonal, and every functional calculus acts blockwise. Let $L_c$, $R_c$, $N_c$ be the expressions of the item for the block variables and $\varphi_{W_c}$. For all items except 11, 16 and 24, $L \leq \sum_c L_c$ (with equality unless $L$ contains an absolute value of a functional, as in 1, 4 and 14), $N = \sum_c N_c$, and $R = \sum_c R_c$, except in items 6 and 14, where $R = \sqrt{\sum_c \varphi_c(A_c) \sum_c \varphi_c(B_c)} \geq \sum_c R_c$ by the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality and $R \geq \sum_c R_c$ by Hölder's inequality. Since $W > 0$, $N_c = 0$ forces the variables of block $c$ to vanish where they enter $L_c$, so $L_c \leq R_c$ there. Hence $(L-R)/N \leq \sum_c (L_c - R_c)/\sum_c N_c \leq \max_c (L_c - R_c)/N_c$, the maximum over the blocks with $N_c > 0$ (for $N = R$ in items 6 and 14 use $L/R \leq \sum_c L_c / \sum_c R_c$ instead). This proves the inequality. For the equality, in the listed items $N$ is additive and the variables may vanish on all blocks but one without making $N$ vanish; restricting a near-optimal configuration of one block and setting the variables to zero on the other blocks reproduces its quotient (in 19, 20 and 15, $N$ contains $\varphi(1)$ and the other blocks dilute the violation). If every $W_c$ is scalar, every $V_{M_{k_c}}(W_c)$ vanishes, since $\varphi_{W_c}$ is then a trace on $M_{k_c}$; for item 16 the same conclusion holds because the Peierls–Bogoliubov inequality holds for every trace on $\mathcal{M}$. □

*Remark* 8.2. The theorem is a statement about the characterisations, not about the inequalities: a non-central density is detected by every characterisation of traces, but only through the variation *inside* the blocks. Items 11 and 24 characterise the *canonical* trace Tr among the functionals with $\varphi(1) = \dim$, and central $W$ violate them; for a fixed density their violations are $1 - \mathrm{GM}/\mathrm{AM}$ and $w_{\min}^{-1/2} - 1$ of the eigenvalues of $W$ normalised to $\mathrm{Tr}\,W = \sum_c k_c$ (Propositions 5.5 and 5.6; the proofs do not use the block structure).

# 9 Numerical verification and the remaining items

## 9.1 Method

All envelopes were computed by constrained optimisation with our PyTorch library `torch_vn_algebra` [24]; the program is `scripts/trace_characterizations.py` of the repository [24]. The density $W$ is diagonal with a spectrum parametrised so that $\Delta(W) = \delta$ holds exactly and the other eigenvalues are free. Positive variables have a free contrast in $[0, 1]$, so rank-deficient operators are included; there are self-adjoint and unitary variables (polar factors, and projections $UDU^*$, with every rank pattern spread over the starts), and positive scalars. Half of the starts begin at structured points (two-level spectra, rotations in pairs of eigenvectors of $W$). The lattice operations are the spectral projections of $P + Q$ for the eigenvalue 2 ($P \wedge Q$) and for the range ($P \vee Q$), computed by functional calculus with an indicator function, whose Daleckii–Krein gradient is the derivative of the spectral projection. In 19 and 23 the suprema are approached as $P$ and $Q$ merge, where $P \wedge Q$ and $P \vee Q$ jump; there the search maximises $(L - R)/N - 10^{-12}/\|P - Q\|_{\mathrm{F}}^2$, which keeps $P$ and $Q$ about $10^{-3}$ apart, while the reported values are those of $(L - R)/N$. A grid of 14 contrasts times 64 starts forms one batch per item and dimension (800 gradient steps, $n = 2, 3, 4$).

*Certification.* The best final point of every contrast is recomputed in mpmath with 40 digits, after the unitaries are re-orthonormalised and the contrast is recomputed from the stored eigenvalues; the lattice operations are recomputed from the exact eigenvalues. Every positive value reported below is thus a certified violation at an exactly admissible point. The double-precision and mpmath values agree to $5 \times 10^{-6}$ (relative), and at $\delta = 0$ no value exceeds $1 \times 10^{-16}$. Independently, plain NumPy/SciPy searches (BFGS from 40 random starts on $M_2$ at $\delta = 0.3, 0.5, 0.9$) give values whose ratio to the batched search lies in $[0.994, 1.097]$; ratios above 1 come from item 13, where BFGS stops earlier. The test suite compares every objective with a plain NumPy implementation and with mpmath, checks that random points stay below the proved envelopes and that the stated extremisers attain them. The whole computation takes 475 s on 4 CPU processes.

## 9.2 Random sampling

Before searching for the extremes we sample. A third program (`scripts/trace_montecarlo.py`, plain NumPy, independent of the library) draws, for each of the 25 items and for $n = 2, 3, 4$, 40000 random functionals on $M_n$ and random operators: $W$ with a uniformly distributed contrast $\Delta(W) \in [0, 1)$ and the other eigenvalues uniform in between, positive operators $U\mathrm{diag}(\lambda)U^*$ with Haar-random $U$, a uniformly distributed contrast and a random scale, arbitrary operators $V|X|$ with a Haar-random $V$, self-adjoint ones with random signs, and Haar-random projections. This is the method of [1, Sect. 5], extended to all items. A second sample replaces every positive operator (every modulus) by a scaled projection of random rank (*projection sample*). The bottom rows of Figures 4–8 show, in bins of $\Delta(W)$, the largest sampled violation divided by the certified envelope; Table 2 gives the fraction of violating samples.

The samples show four things.

(a) *No sample exceeds the envelope*: the largest ratio of a sampled violation to the certified envelope at the upper edge of its bin is 1.006 over all items and dimensions (the excess over 1 is the linear interpolation between grid values of the envelope). This is an independent check of the computed envelopes.

(b) *Random operators rarely come close to the envelope*, and for monotonicity, subadditivity, the Powers–Størmer inequality and the weighted monotonicity essentially never violate it: less than

| item | inequality | $M_2$ random | $M_2$ proj. | $M_3$ random | $M_3$ proj. | $M_4$ random | $M_4$ proj. |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Gardner | 4.5 | 18.7 | $< 0.1$ | 2.8 | $< 0.1$ | 0.6 |
| 2 | triangle | 1.1 | 6.4 | $< 0.1$ | 6.3 | $< 0.1$ | 4.5 |
| 3 | $\varphi(A{+}A^*)$ | 0.6 | 3.2 | $< 0.1$ | 0.4 | 0 | $< 0.1$ |
| 4 | $\lvert\varphi(A^2)\rvert$ | 6.4 | 6.9 | 0.2 | 0.5 | $< 0.1$ | $< 0.1$ |
| 5 | metric | 0 | – | $< 0.1$ | – | $< 0.1$ | – |
| 6 | geom. mean | 0.1 | – | 0 | – | 0 | – |
| 7 | ALT | 19.2 | 0 | 14.2 | 0 | 11.2 | 0 |
| 8 | Young (ext.) | 7.6 | 8.4 | 3.0 | 2.1 | 1.6 | 0.6 |
| 9 | Bikchentaev-Abed | 49.7 | – | 50.2 | – | 50.1 | – |
| 10 | monotonicity | $< 0.1$ | 0.7 | 0 | $< 0.1$ | 0 | $< 0.1$ |
| 11 | AM-GM | 20.6 | – | 13.3 | – | 9.9 | – |
| 12 | subadditivity | $< 0.1$ | 21.1 | 0 | 8.9 | 0 | 5.1 |
| 13 | Powers-Stormer | $< 0.1$ | 8.9 | 0 | 3.0 | 0 | 1.4 |
| 14 | Hoelder | 1.4 | – | $< 0.1$ | – | 0 | – |
| 15 | Golden-Thompson | 25.6 | – | 16.8 | – | 11.6 | – |
| 16 | Peierls-Bogoliubov | 2.4 | 1.8 | 0.7 | 0.4 | 0.4 | 0.1 |
| 17 | $\varphi(PQP)$ | 12.0 | – | 3.8 | – | 2.0 | – |
| 18 | $\varphi(\lvert P-Q\rvert)$ | 13.2 | – | 4.3 | – | 1.9 | – |
| 19 | $P \wedge Q$ | 49.9 | – | 37.8 | – | 33.4 | – |
| 20 | $e^{QPQ}$ | 8.0 | – | 2.1 | – | 1.0 | – |
| 21 | $\mathrm{Re}PQ \geq 0$ | 5.5 | – | 1.4 | – | 0.5 | – |
| 22 | $\mathrm{Re}PQ \leq \lvert PQ\rvert$ | 14.5 | – | 7.8 | – | 4.3 | – |
| 23 | $P \vee Q$ | 49.6 | – | 38.0 | – | 33.6 | – |
| 24 | power mean | 7.3 | 49.6 | 0.3 | 25.0 | $< 0.1$ | 16.7 |
| 25 | weighted mon. | 0 | 0 | 0 | 0 | 0 | 0 |

Table 2: Random sampling, 40000 samples per item, class and dimension: the percentage of samples that violate the inequality, for random operators and for scaled projections. "–": not applicable (the variables are projections, or an invertible operator is needed).

0.1% of the samples (or none) violate. A Monte Carlo study alone would conclude that these inequalities hold for every $\varphi_W$.

(c) *Sampling gets worse with the dimension*: for Gardner's inequality the fraction of violating random samples drops from 4.5% on $M_2$ to 0.1% on $M_3$ and to none of the 40000 samples on $M_4$, and the best sample stays far below the envelope (Figure 5). The extremal configurations, rank-one operators on a two-dimensional subspace aligned with the extreme eigenvectors of $W$, have a Haar measure that decreases rapidly with $n$.

(d) *Projections detect the failure.* Sampling scaled projections instead of general positive operators raises the fraction of violating samples in every dimension, for Gardner's inequality from 4.5% to 18.7% on $M_2$ and from 0 to 0.6% on $M_4$, for subadditivity from below 0.1% to 21%, 9% and 5% on $M_2$, $M_3$, $M_4$, for the power-mean inequality from 7% to 50% on $M_2$, and brings the best sample close to the envelope (dashed lines in the bottom rows). The exceptions are those of Section 9.3: for items 4 and 7 the extremisers are two-level operators that are not projections (for item 7 the violation degenerates exactly at projections), and items 6 and 11 need invertible operators.

### 9.3 Do projections suffice?

For the 14 items whose variables are not projections, a second program (`scripts/trace_contrast.py`) repeats the search with the positive variables (the moduli, for the others) restricted in two ways: to two-level operators $c(\ell + (1-\ell)P)$ with free $\ell \in [0,1]$, $c > 0$ and a projection $P$ of any rank (for self-adjoint variables $\alpha + \beta P$ with free real $\alpha, \beta$), and to scaled projections $cP$. Everything else is as before (64 starts per grid point, 800 gradient steps, best final point recomputed in mpmath with 40 digits); the whole computation of this and the next subsection takes 760 s on four CPU processes.

| | $M_2$ | | | | | | $M_3$ | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | $\delta = 0.5$ | | | $\delta = 0.9$ | | | $\delta = 0.5$ | | | $\delta = 0.9$ | | |
| item | all | two-level | proj. | all | two-level | proj. | all | two-level | proj. | all | two-level | proj. |
| 1 | 0.1547 | 0.1547 | 0.1547 | 1.2942 | 1.2942 | 1.2942 | 0.1547 | 0.1547 | 0.1547 | 1.2942 | 1.2942 | 1.2942 |
| 2 | 0.1547 | 0.1547 | 0.1547 | 1.2942 | 1.2941 | 1.2942 | 0.1547 | 0.1547 | 0.1547 | 1.2942 | 1.2941 | 1.2942 |
| 3 | 0.1547 | 0.1547 | 0.1547 | 1.2942 | 1.2942 | 1.2942 | 0.1547 | 0.1547 | 0.1547 | 1.2942 | 1.2942 | 1.2942 |
| 4 | 0.1547 | 0.1547 | 0.0774 | 1.2942 | 1.2942 | 0.6471 | 0.1547 | 0.1328 | 0.0774 | 1.2942 | 1.2612 | 0.7393 |
| 6 | 0.1427 | 0 | 0.1501 | 1.2139 | 1.1707 | 1.2924 | 0.1359 | 0 | 0.1491 | 1.2125 | 1.1405 | 1.2922 |
| 7 | 0.2656 | 0.2730 | 0 | 3.4387 | 3.5241 | 0 | 0.2733 | 0.2703 | 0 | 3.4965 | 3.4358 | 0 |
| 8 | 2.0000 | 2.0000 | 2.0000 | 18.00 | 18.00 | 18.00 | 2.0000 | 2.0000 | 2.0000 | 18.00 | 18.00 | 18.00 |
| 10 | 0.0052 | 0.0052 | 0.0052 | 0.1825 | 0.1825 | 0.1825 | 0.0052 | 0.0052 | 0.0052 | 0.1825 | 0.1825 | 0.1825 |
| 11 | 0.1340 | 0.1340 | – | 0.5641 | 0.5641 | – | 0.1347 | 0.1347 | – | 0.6188 | 0.6188 | – |
| 12 | 0.1338 | 0.1338 | 0.1338 | 0.9678 | 0.9679 | 0.9680 | 0.1338 | 0.1338 | 0.1338 | 0.9678 | 0.9675 | 0.9680 |
| 13 | 0.0911 | 0.0329 | 0.0911 | 0.2197 | 0.2171 | 0.2197 | 0.0911 | 0.0911 | 0.0911 | 0.3048 | 0.2057 | 0.2197 |
| 16 | 0.0560 | 0.0561 | 0.0560 | 0.8885 | 0.8885 | 0.8873 | 0.0561 | 0.0561 | 0.0560 | 0.8894 | 0.8887 | 0.8864 |
| 24 | 0.4142 | 0.4142 | 0.4142 | 2.1623 | 2.1623 | 2.1623 | 0.5275 | 0.5275 | 0.5275 | 2.6056 | 2.6056 | 2.6056 |
| 25 | $1.6 \cdot 10^{-6}$ | $1.4 \cdot 10^{-6}$ | 0 | 0.0017 | 0.0017 | 0 | $5.3 \cdot 10^{-7}$ | $2.2 \cdot 10^{-8}$ | 0 | 0.0017 | 0.0017 | 0 |

Table 3: Certified largest violations over all operators, over two-level operators and over scaled projections, for the items whose variables are not projections. In $M_2$ every operator is two-level, so there the middle column only checks the restricted parametrisation. "–": item 11 needs an invertible $A$.

Table 3 shows four groups.

(a) *Projections attain the envelope*: items 1, 2, 3, 8, 10, 12, 16 and 24 in $M_2$ and $M_3$ (item 16 to within 0.3%), and item 13 in $M_2$. Together with the 11 items whose variables are projections by definition, this covers 20 of the 25 items.

(b) *Projections approach it*: in items 6 and 7 the supremum is approached as an operator becomes a projection, where both sides of the inequality degenerate. Restricted to projections (item 6) or to two-level operators (item 7), the search comes closer to the proved lower bound $\kappa - 1$, resp. $\kappa^2 - 1$, than without restriction: the restriction helps the search.

(c) *Two-level operators are needed*: item 4 (the extremiser $A = \sqrt{a}\, e_1 e_2^* + \sqrt{b}\, e_2 e_1^*$ has $|A|$ with the eigenvalues $\sqrt{a}, \sqrt{b}$), item 11 ($A = W^{-1}$) and item 25 ($A$ with the eigenvalue ratio $\approx \delta^2/8$, Proposition 7.2; rank-one $A$ gives no violation). In $M_3$ the extremiser of item 4 lives on a two-dimensional subspace and vanishes on its complement, so it has three eigenvalues $\sqrt{a}, \sqrt{b}, 0$; the two-level class without 0 misses it.

(d) *Exceptions*: in $M_3$ at $\delta = 0.9$ the generalised Powers–Størmer inequality (item 13) is violated by 0.3048 against 0.2197 for projections and for $M_2$, and the spectral geometric mean (item 6) exceeds $\kappa - 1$ for $n \geq 3$ (Section 9, item (iii) below). Here operators that are not two-level do more.

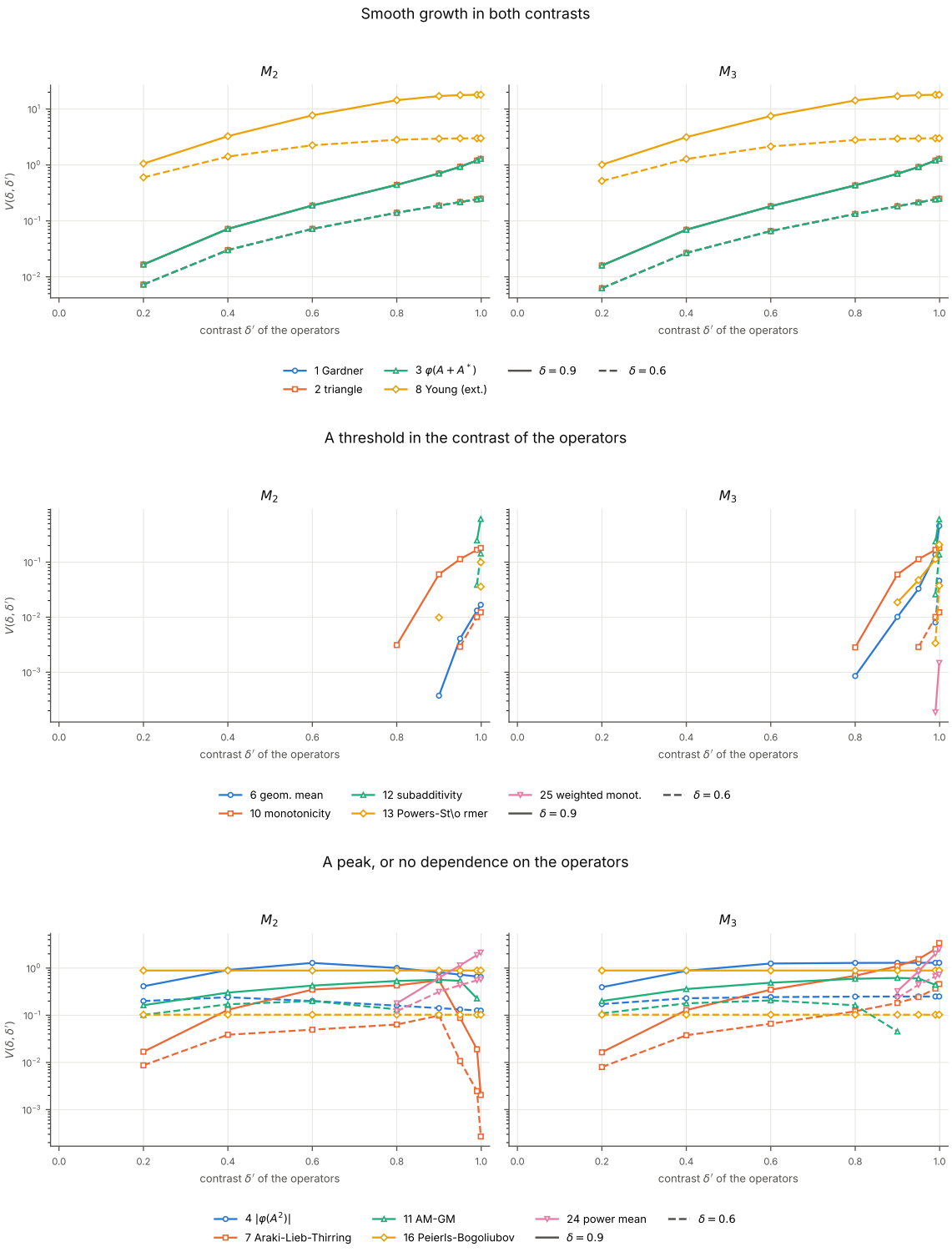



Figure 3: Certified largest violation $V(\delta, \delta')$ with every operator variable of contrast $\delta'$, on $M_2$ (left) and $M_3$ (right), for $\delta = \Delta(W) = 0.9$ (solid) and 0.6 (dashed); logarithmic scale, points without a violation omitted. Top: smooth growth (items 1–3 follow Theorem 4.1, item 8 Proposition 5.3). Middle: violation only for operators of contrast close to 1. Bottom: a peak in $\delta'$ (items 4, 7 on $M_2$, item 11 at the contrast of $W$), no dependence on $\delta' > 0$ (item 16), and item 24.

### 9.4 Both contrasts

Figure 3 shows $V(\delta, \delta')$ for the same 14 items. At $\delta' = 0$ no item is violated (Proposition 2.4). Beyond that, the items fall into four classes.

(a) *Smooth growth in both contrasts*: items 1–3 follow Theorem 4.1 to $1 \times 10^{-9}$ (relative, $n = 2, 3$, all grid points); item 8 follows Proposition 5.3 on $M_2$.

(b) *A threshold in the contrast of the operators*: items 6, 10, 12, 13, 24 and 25 show no violation until $\delta'$ is close to 1; at $\delta = 0.9$ the first grid value with a violation above $10^{-4}$ is: 6 ($n = 2$): 0.9; 6 ($n = 3$): 0.8; 10 ($n = 2$): 0.8; 10 ($n = 3$): 0.8; 12 ($n = 2$): 0.99; 12 ($n = 3$): 0.99; 13 ($n = 2$): 0.9; 13 ($n = 3$): 0.9; 24 ($n = 2$): 0.8; 24 ($n = 3$): 0.9; 25 ($n = 2$): –; 25 ($n = 3$): 0.99. These characterisations are blind to operators of moderate contrast: their violation needs nearly singular operators.

(c) *A peak*: item 11 is violated most strongly when the contrast of $A$ is close to that of $W$ (its extremiser is $W^{-1}$), and in $M_2$ items 4 and 7 have an interior maximum in $\delta'$ (for item 4 at the contrast of $|A|$ of the extremiser in (c) above); in $M_3$ the additional dimension removes the maxima of 4 and 7.

(d) *No dependence on the contrast of the operators*: item 16 is invariant under $A \mapsto A + c$, $B \mapsto B + c$, which makes the contrasts of $A$ and $B$ arbitrarily small without changing the quotient; accordingly $V(\delta, \delta')$ equals the envelope with free operators for every $\delta' > 0$ and jumps to 0 at $\delta' = 0$.

On $M_2$ every spectrum is two-level. On $M_3$ the two-level operators of contrast $\delta'$ reproduce the values of general spectra with the same contrast except in items 4, 6 and 7 near $\delta' = 1$: there the extremisers need a third eigenvalue (a zero on the complement of a two-dimensional subspace, or a nearly singular second operator).

### 9.5 Envelopes with the operators free

| items | $V^\star(\delta)$ | as $\delta \to 0$ | $V^\star(0.5)$ | search $V(0.5)$ | status |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 8 | $h - 1 = 2\delta/(1-\delta)$ | $2\delta$ | 2.0000 | 2.0000 | sharp |
| 9 | $s/(1+s)$, $s = \sin\frac{\psi}{2}$ | $\delta/2$ | 0.2056 | 0.2056 | sharp for $n = 2$ |
| 19 | $\delta$ | $\delta$ | 0.5000 | 0.5000 | sharp, approached |
| 23 | $\delta/(1-\delta)$ | $\delta$ | 1.0000 | 1.0000 | sharp, approached |
| 24 | $(1-\delta)^{-1/2} - 1$ | $\delta/2$ | 0.4142 | 0.4142 | sharp for $n = 2$; grows with $n$ |
| 1–5, 18, 22 | $\kappa - 1$ | $\delta^2/2$ | 0.1547 | 0.1547 | sharp |
| 17 | $\kappa^2 - 1$ | $\delta^2$ | 0.3333 | 0.3333 | sharp |
| 11 | $1 - \sqrt{1-\delta^2}$ | $\delta^2/2$ | 0.1340 | 0.1340 | sharp for $n = 2$; grows with $n$ |
| 20 | max. of one variable | $\frac{(e-1)^2}{e(e+1)}\delta^2$ | 0.0802 | 0.0802 | sharp |
| 21 | $\frac{1}{2}\tan^2(\psi/2)$ | $\delta^2/8$ | 0.0359 | 0.0359 | sharp |
| 6 | $\geq \kappa - 1$ | $\geq \delta^2/2$ | 0.1547 | 0.1430 | lower bound |
| 7 | $\geq \kappa^2 - 1$ | $\geq \delta^2$ | 0.3333 | 0.2653 | lower bound |
| 12–16 | – | $c\,\delta^2$, $c \in [\frac{1}{36}, \frac{1}{2}]$ | – | 0.0086–0.1338 | search |
| 10 | $\geq m(\delta)$ | $\geq \delta^4/16$ | 0.0052 | 0.0052 | lower bound |
| 25 | $\geq m_{25}(\delta)$ | $\geq \delta^8/4096$ | $1.7 \times 10^{-6}$ | $1.5 \times 10^{-6}$ | lower bound |

Table 4: Classes of behaviour, ordered by the order of vanishing of the envelope at the trace. $V^\star$: the sharp value or, where marked $\geq$, a proved lower bound; "search": the certified search value on $M_2$ (a range over the items of a row). Items 11 and 24 are given for $n = 2$.

Tables 4 and 5 and Figures 4–8 summarise the computation.

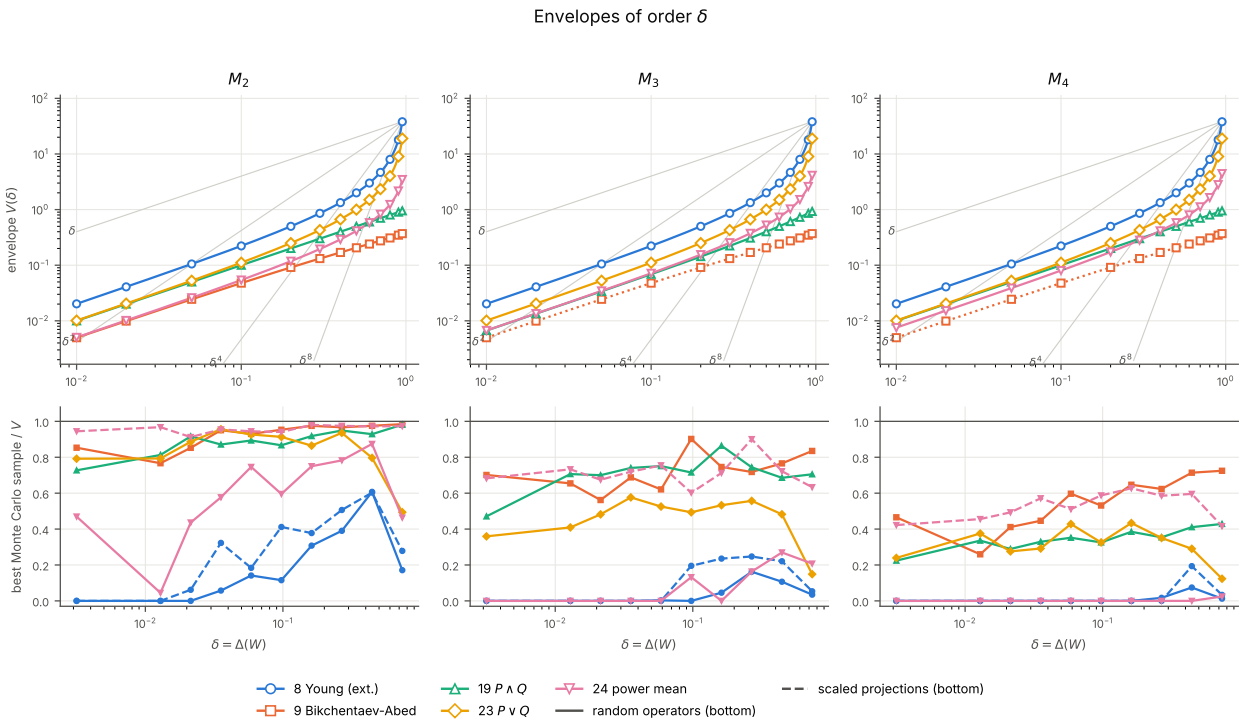



Figure 4: Envelopes of order $\delta$ (items 8, 9, 19, 23, 24). Top: $V(\delta)$ on logarithmic axes for $M_2$, $M_3$ and $M_4$; markers: certified search; lines: proved values; grey guides: $\delta^k$, so that the order of vanishing is the slope. Bottom: the best random sample in each bin of $\delta$ divided by the envelope, for random operators (solid) and scaled projections (dashed).

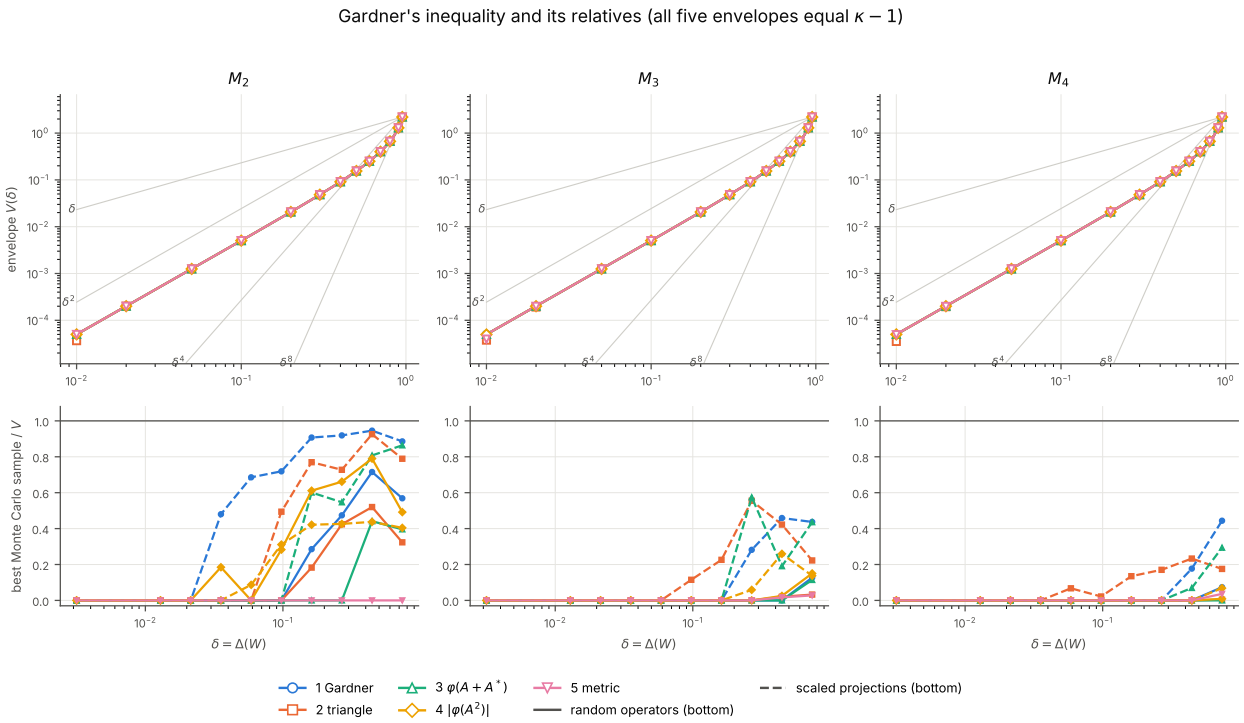



Figure 5: Gardner's inequality and its relatives (items 1–5), as in Figure 4. All five envelopes equal $\kappa - 1$ in every dimension (Theorem 3.1); the random samples fall further behind as $n$ grows.

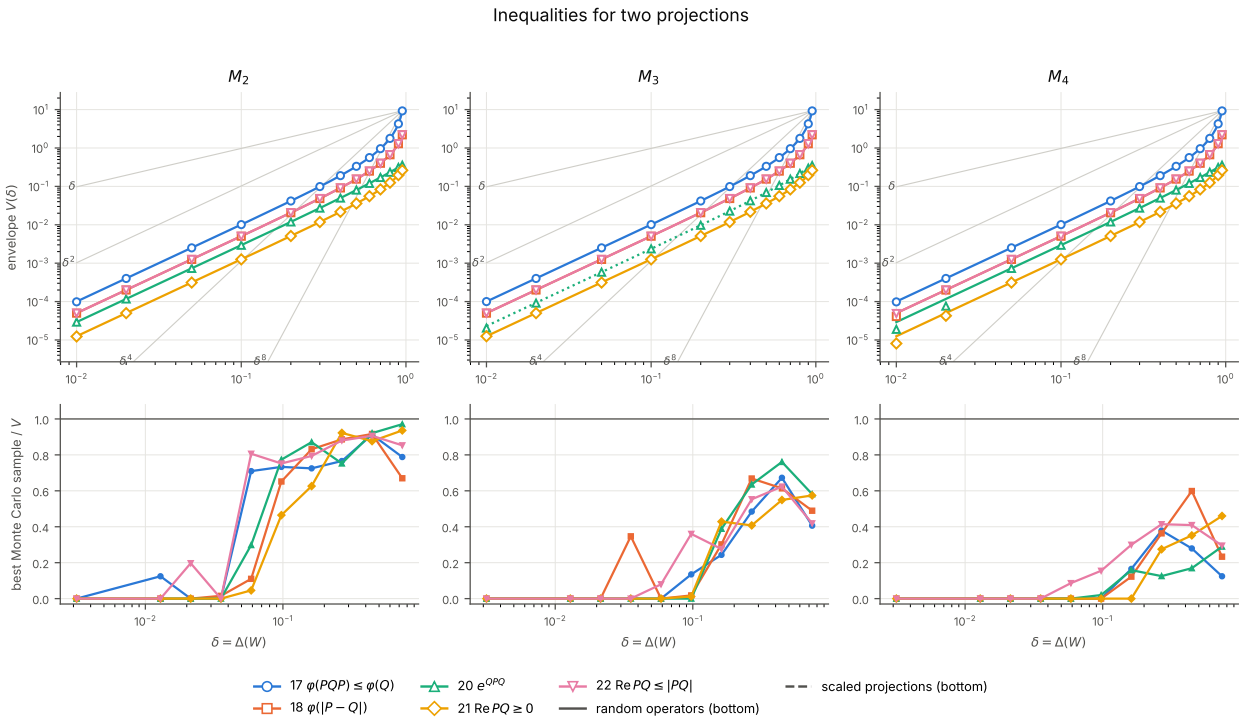



Figure 6: Inequalities for two projections of order $\delta^2$ (items 17, 18, 20, 21, 22), as in Figure 4 (Theorem 6.1).

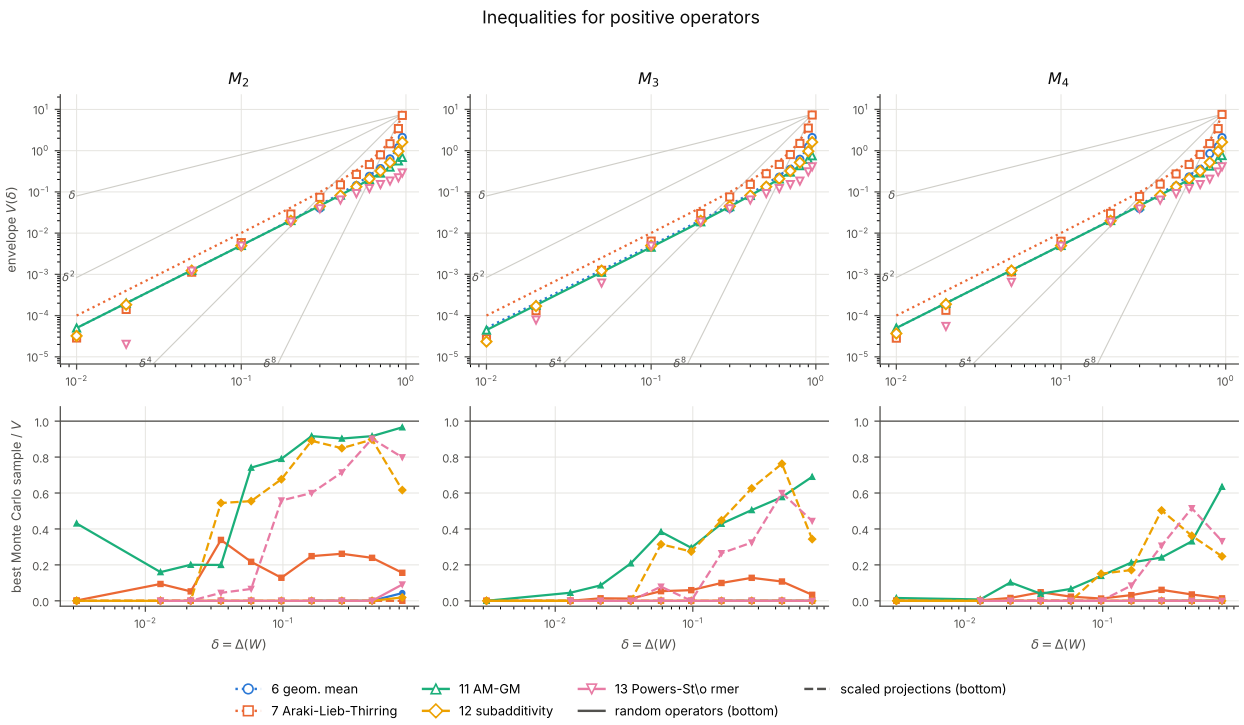



Figure 7: Inequalities for positive operators (items 6, 7, 11, 12, 13), as in Figure 4; dotted lines are the lower bounds of Proposition 7.1.

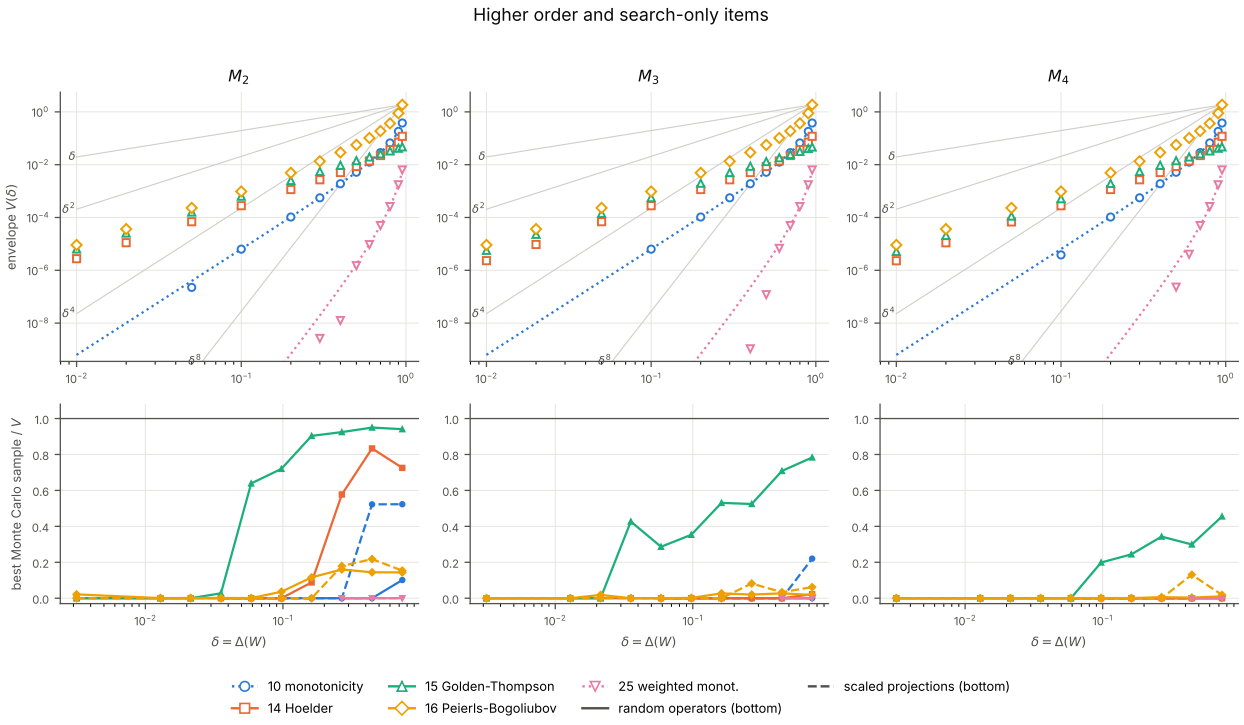



Figure 8: Monotonicity ($\delta^4$, item 10), its weighted form ($\delta^8$, item 25), and the items known only from the search (14–16), as in Figure 4.

| | inequality $L \le R$ | ref. | $V(0.1)$ | $V(0.5)$ | $V(0.9)$ | $V^\star(0.5)$ | order | slope | $n$-dep. |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | $\lvert\varphi(X)\rvert \le \varphi(\lvert X\rvert)$ | [18] | 0.0050 | 0.1547 | 1.2942 | 0.1547 | $\delta^2$ | 2.03 | $4\times10^{-10}$ |
| 2 | $\varphi(\lvert X+Y\rvert) \le \varphi(\lvert X\rvert)+\varphi(\lvert Y\rvert)$ | [18, 30] | 0.0050 | 0.1547 | 1.2942 | 0.1547 | $\delta^2$ | 2.03 | $1\times10^{-9}$ |
| 3 | $\varphi(A+A^*) \le 2\varphi(\lvert A^*\rvert)$ | [10] | 0.0050 | 0.1547 | 1.2942 | 0.1547 | $\delta^2$ | 2.03 | $5\times10^{-10}$ |
| 4 | $\lvert\varphi(A^2)\rvert \le \varphi(A^*A)$ | [27, 14] | 0.0050 | 0.1547 | 1.2942 | 0.1547 | $\delta^2$ | 2.03 | $1\times10^{-8}$ |
| 5 | $\varphi(\lvert P-R\rvert) \le \varphi(\lvert P-Q\rvert)+\varphi(\lvert Q-R\rvert)$ | [11] | 0.0050 | 0.1547 | 1.2942 | 0.1547 | $\delta^2$ | 2.03 | $1\times10^{-8}$ |
| 6 | $\varphi(A\natural B) \le \sqrt{\varphi(A)\varphi(B)}$ | [15] | n.r. | 0.1430 | 1.1979 | $0.1547^b$ | $\delta^2$ | – | $n\ge3$ |
| 7 | $\varphi((B^{1/2}AB^{1/2})^2) \le \varphi(BA^2B)$ | [9] | 0.0059 | 0.2653 | 3.4322 | $0.3333^b$ | $\delta^2$ | 2.31 | $9\times10^{-2}$ |
| 8 | $\varphi(\lvert AB^*\rvert) \le \frac12\varphi(\lvert A\rvert^2)+\frac12\varphi(\lvert B\rvert^2)$ | [4] | 0.2222 | 2.0000 | 18.00 | 2.0000 | $\delta^1$ | 1.17 | $9\times10^{-12}$ |
| 9 | $\varphi(PQ+QP) \le 2\varphi(QPQ)$ | [10] | 0.0477 | 0.2056 | 0.3469 | $0.2056^a$ | $\delta^1$ | 0.94 | $3\times10^{-10}$ |
| 10 | $0\le A\le B \Rightarrow \varphi(A^2)\le\varphi(B^2)$ | [5, 28, 22] | $6.3\times10^{-6}$ | 0.0052 | 0.1825 | $0.0052^b$ | $\delta^4$ | 4.04 | $3\times10^{-8}$ |
| 11 | $(\det A)^{1/n} \le \frac1n\varphi(A)$, $\varphi(1)=n$ | [12] | 0.0050 | 0.1340 | 0.5641 | 0.1340 | $\delta^2$ | 2.01 | yes |
| 12 | $\varphi((A+B)^{1/2}) \le \varphi(A^{1/2})+\varphi(B^{1/2})$ | [31] | 0.0050 | 0.1338 | 0.9678 | – | – | 2.00 | $5\times10^{-4}$ |
| 13 | $\varphi(A+B-\lvert A-B\rvert) \le 2\varphi(A^{1/4}B^{1/2}A^{1/4})$ | [23] | 0.0048 | 0.0911 | 0.2197 | – | – | 1.93 | $4\times10^{-1}$ |
| 14 | $\lvert\varphi(PQ)\rvert \le \varphi(P)^{1/3}\varphi(Q)^{2/3}$ | [8, 10] | $2.8\times10^{-4}$ | 0.0086 | 0.0711 | – | – | 2.03 | $4\times10^{-3}$ |
| 15 | $\varphi(e^{P+Q}) \le \varphi(e^{P/2}e^Qe^{P/2})$ | [8] | $6.4\times10^{-4}$ | 0.0142 | 0.0420 | – | – | 1.98 | $2\times10^{-1}$ |
| 16 | $\varphi(e^A)e^{\varphi(e^{A/2}Be^{A/2})/\varphi(e^A)} \le \varphi(e^{A+B})$ | [9] | $9.7\times10^{-4}$ | 0.0561 | 0.8890 | – | – | 2.35 | $2\times10^{-3}$ |
| 17 | $\varphi(PQP) \le \varphi(Q)$ | [7] | 0.0101 | 0.3333 | 4.2632 | 0.3333 | $\delta^2$ | 2.04 | $7\times10^{-9}$ |
| 18 | $\varphi(\lvert P-Q\rvert) \le \varphi(P+Q)$ | [7] | 0.0050 | 0.1547 | 1.2942 | 0.1547 | $\delta^2$ | 2.03 | $1\times10^{-8}$ |
| 19 | $\varphi(P+Q) \le \varphi(1+P\wedge Q)$ | [7] | 0.1000 | 0.5000 | 0.9000 | $0.5000^c$ | $\delta^1$ | 1.00 | odd $n$ |
| 20 | $\varphi(e^{QPQ}) \le \varphi(e^P)$ | [8] | 0.0029 | 0.0802 | 0.3115 | 0.0802 | $\delta^2$ | 2.02 | odd $n$ |
| 21 | $\varphi(\mathrm{Re}\,PQ) \ge 0$ | [8] | 0.0013 | 0.0359 | 0.1964 | 0.0359 | $\delta^2$ | 2.02 | $8\times10^{-9}$ |
| 22 | $\varphi(\mathrm{Re}\,PQ) \le \varphi(\lvert PQ\rvert)$ | [8] | 0.0050 | 0.1547 | 1.2942 | 0.1547 | $\delta^2$ | 2.03 | $5\times10^{-9}$ |
| 23 | $\varphi(P\vee Q) \le \varphi(P)+\varphi(Q)$ | [27] | 0.1111 | 1.0000 | 9.0000 | $1.0000^c$ | $\delta^1$ | 1.17 | $4\times10^{-7}$ |
| 24 | $\varphi(A^2)^{1/2} \le \varphi(A)$, $\varphi(1)=n$ | [12] | 0.0541 | 0.4142 | 2.1623 | 0.4142 | $\delta^1$ | 1.13 | yes |
| 25 | $0\le A\le B \Rightarrow \varphi(A^4)\le\varphi(AB^2A)$ | [22] | n.r. | $1.5\times10^{-6}$ | 0.0017 | $1.7\times10^{-6b}$ | $\delta^8$ | – | $3\times10^{-6}$ |

Table 5: Certified search values on $M_2$ at $\delta = 0.1, 0.5, 0.9$ and the proved values $V^\star$; $^a$: sharp for $n=2$ only, $^b$: a lower bound, $^c$: approached but not attained. "order": leading order of $V^\star$ as $\delta\to0$; "slope": $\log_2(V(0.2)/V(0.1))$ of the search; "$n$-dep.": the largest $|V_n/V_2-1|$ for $n=3,4$ and $\delta\ge0.1$ (for item 7 it reflects search shortfalls, for item 13 a genuine increase with $n$; items 19 and 20 differ for odd $n$, Theorem 6.1). "n.r.": no violation resolved by the search (*full* run on $CPU(4threads)$).

(i) *Agreement with the theorems.* Where the envelope is known exactly and attained (items 1–5, 8, 11, and 9 for $n=2$), the search reproduces it to $1\times10^{-7}$ for $\delta\ge0.05$ and $n=2,3,4$; for items 17, 18, 20–22 and 24 to $3\times10^{-4}$, and for the approached suprema of 19 and 23 to $2\times10^{-6}$. Apart from item 6 with $n\ge3$, no value exceeds the lower bounds of Section 7 (largest relative excess $1\times10^{-16}$). The values of 17, 18 and 21–23 on $M_3$ and $M_4$ agree with the $M_2$ values to $4\times10^{-7}$, as Theorem 6.1 predicts, and the search on $M_3$ finds the odd-$n$ value 0.0694 of item 20 at $\delta=0.5$ ($M_2$: 0.0802).

(ii) *Items without a closed form.* All five items 12–16 fail quadratically, with $V\approx0.5\,\delta^2$ (12, 13), $\delta^2/36$ (14, equal to the bound of Proposition 7.1(d) to leading order), $0.064\,\delta^2$ (15) and $0.09\,\delta^2$ (16). Item 15 decreases with $n$, because the identity part of $e^{P/2}e^Qe^{P/2}$ enters $N$; item 13 increases with $n$ at large $\delta$ (on $M_3$ at $\delta=0.9$: 0.3048 against 0.2197 on $M_2$, both certified); items 12, 14 and 16 give the same values for $n=2,3,4$. In item 16 the best points have large $\|A\|$, $\|B\|$, and the supremum is approached as the scale grows.

(iii) *Dimension.* For items 9 and 10 the search gives the same values for $n=3,4$ as for $n=2$, to $4\times10^{-3}$. Item 6 depends on $n$: for $n=2$ the search never exceeds $\kappa-1$, but for $n\ge3$ it certifies larger violations, $V\ge0.847$ at $n=4$, $\delta=0.8$, where $\kappa-1=0.667$; a stored point gives $V>2.1$ at $n=3$, $\delta=0.9$, where $\kappa-1=1.29$. We only know $\kappa-1\le V_6\le h-1$.

(iv) *Extremisers.* Except for items 6 ($n\ge3$), 11 ($A=W^{-1}$) and 25 ($A$ of rank two with eigenvalue ratio $\approx\delta^2/8$), the extremisers are rank-one operators or matrix units in the span of eigenvectors for $a$ and $b$, and they do not commute with $W$.

(v) *Limits of the search.* The suprema of 6 and 7 are approached only as an operator becomes singular; gradient ascent reaches 0.924 and 0.796 of the bound at $\delta = 0.5$, and finds no violation of item 6 for $\delta \leq 0.2$. Item 25 is resolved for $\delta \geq 0.3$; the search reaches $m_{25}$ to $10^{-3}$ for $\delta \geq 0.7$ and does not exceed it.

(vi) *Direct sums.* On $M_2 \oplus M_3$ with $W = 1 \oplus s1$ and $W = \mathrm{diag}(1, \ell) \oplus s1$, $s \in \{\frac{1}{4}, 4\}$, intra-block contrast $\delta \in \{0.3, 0.5, 0.7\}$: for central $W$ the largest value found for the items that hold for every trace is $1 \times 10^{-16}$; for 11 and 24 the search reproduces the exact values for the fixed density to $2 \times 10^{-11}$; with intra-block contrast no value exceeds the $M_2$ envelope (largest relative excess $1 \times 10^{-16}$), and where Theorem 8.1 gives equality the search reaches it to $10^{-3}$ in 63 of 72 cases.

## 10 Conclusions and open problems

For the 25 characterisations of the trace studied here, the violation of the inequality by a non-tracial functional $\varphi_W$ is controlled by two Michelson contrasts, that of $W$ and that of the operators: it vanishes if either is zero, and for Gardner's inequality and its relatives it is an explicit function of their product. The largest violation is found, with few exceptions, at projections or at two-level operators $\ell + (1-\ell)P$, as the vertex principle predicts where it applies. Testing a characterisation on projections and their affine images is therefore the efficient way to detect a non-tracial functional, and the size of the violation measures the contrast of its density. The exceptions are structural: thresholds in the contrast of the operators, a peak at the contrast of the density for the determinant inequality, shift invariance for the Peierls–Bogoliubov inequality, and, in dimension three, the spectral geometric mean and the generalised Powers–Størmer inequality.

**Conjecture 10.1.** $V_n = \kappa^2 - 1$ for item 7, $V_n = m(\delta)$ for item 10 and $V_n = m_{25}(\delta)$ for item 25 in every dimension; $V_2 = \kappa - 1$ for item 6; and the value of Proposition 5.4 holds for item 9 in every dimension.

Further questions: (0) proofs of the threshold phenomenon of Section 9.4(b), i.e. of inequalities that hold for every $\varphi_W$ as long as the operators have contrast below a critical value depending on $\Delta(W)$, and of the equality in Proposition 5.3; (1) the envelope of item 6 for $n \geq 3$, where the search exceeds $\kappa - 1$, and whether it grows with $n$; (2) closed forms for items 12–16, whose leading coefficients the search gives as $\frac{1}{2}$, $\frac{1}{2}$, $\frac{1}{36}$, 0.064 and 0.09 (item 14: the leading coefficient $(1 - \frac{2}{p})^2/4$ is a lower bound); (3) the analogues for infinite-dimensional von Neumann algebras, where the contrast of an unbounded density may be 1 while the functional is still close to a trace in other senses; (4) envelopes for other inequalities that characterise traces, e.g. those of [25, 15] with the arithmetic mean, and for the dual problem of characterising central elements [26].

**Code availability.** The library, the program that computes all numbers, tables and the figure, and the tests are available at `https://github.com/andre-a-no/von_neumann_type_i` (MIT licence).

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